

Edict of Unity



Ubi Fredrick

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By

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Dedication



To the Bridge-Builders.

To those who understand that a name is but a vessel, and that the blood within it flows with the same rhythm, regardless of the letters we use to spell it.

To the Fredricks who provide the iron and the earth—the silent strength that holds the world together when the storms begin to howl.

To the Fredericks who provide the silver and the light—the eloquence and the vision that give our struggles meaning and our history a voice.

This book is dedicated to the reluctant leaders; to the woodcutters and the quiet watchers who would rather seek the shade of a tree than the heat of a throne, but who stand when the call for unity becomes too loud to ignore.

And finally, to you, the reader: May you find the "E" in your own life—not as a wall to separate you from your neighbor, but as the bridge that finally brings you home.

Two Names. One Blood. One Kingdom.

Preface



The Weight of a Vowel

The inspiration for this work began with a simple observation of the name Fredrick. To some, it is a complete thought—a name of iron, brevity, and unyielding tradition. Truly, a peaceful ruler or warrior. To others, it feels unfinished without the middle "E," the Frederick that suggests a more polished, scholarly, and "Eloquent" existence. This book is a meditation on that divide. It explores how a single character in a name can become a fortress, a weapon, and eventually, a tomb. In this medieval world, "Rick" is not just a suffix; it is the root of "Richness" and "Rulership." By populating this realm with characters whose very names dictate their aptitude—from the bold Kenrick to the noble Ulrica—I wanted to show that while names may define our starting point, it is our actions that define our legacy. This is a story for anyone who has ever felt trapped by a label and for those who believe that peace is not just the absence of war, but the presence of a shared identity.

“In fighting for your right, do not lose your left; because, when brothers fight, strangers inherit.”

— Ubi Fredrick

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Prelude



The Ridge of the Twin Shadows

Before the Wall of the Suffix was ever carved from granite, there was only the Ridge. Legend tells of the day the first twins, Fredrick the Steadfast and Frederick the Eloquent, stood against the black tide of the North. They did not argue over whose name was written first in the royal ledgers or which spelling carried the divine right to rule. They stood back-to-back, a singular pulse of iron and silver in the face of certain death. As they fell, their blood mingled in the soil of the Vale of Rickard, creating a singular stain that no rain could wash away. They died to save a kingdom that was one heart with two names. But as their bodies grew cold, the seeds of vanity were planted by those they left behind. The "E" was pulled from the name like a splinter from a wound, and the great divide began. This is the echo of their final breath—a story of how the silence of a woodcutter finally answered the shouting of eighty years of kings.

Part I:

The Great Divide

- **Chapter 1: The Wall of the Splintered Vowel –**
The deep-seated rivalry between the Eastern Fredericks and the Western Fredricks reaches a breaking point.
- **Chapter 2: Shades of the Larch-Wood Siege –**
Introducing Fredrick, the reluctant heir living as a common woodcutter in Stone-Brook.
- **Chapter 3: Silence of the Empty Dais –**
The Council of Ricks realizes they are defenseless against outside threats without a King to unify the name.

Chapter 1: The Wall of the Splintered Vowel



The sky over the Valley of Oakhaven did not bleed red; it bruised a deep, suffocating purple, choked by the smoke of a thousand funeral pyres. The air was thick with the copper tang of blood and the scorched scent of iron. This was the end of the War of the Suffixes, a conflict that had already claimed the youth of a generation, leaving behind only the hollowed-out husks of men and the bitter resolve of two brothers.

At the center of the carnage stood the Twin Shields: Fredrick the Steadfast and Frederick the Eloquent.

They were identical in stature, both possessing the broad shoulders and steady grey eyes of the ancient Royal Lineage. Yet, even in the heat of battle, their differences were their strength. Fredrick, the elder by mere minutes, wore armor of blackened steel, unadorned and functional—a man of few words and immovable action. Frederick, his twin, wore a breastplate etched with silver filigree, his sword hilt wrapped in fine wire, a man whose voice could rally a retreating line as effectively as a bugle call.

"The Garrick vanguard is breaking through the western ridge," Frederick shouted, his voice rasping through a throat dry from shouting commands. He leaned heavily on his shield, the blue-and-gold crest of the "E-Clan" dented and scarred. "If the ridge falls, the village below is ash, brother."

Fredrick adjusted his grip on his heavy broadsword. His leather gloves were slick with sweat. "Then the ridge does not fall. We hold the high ground. We hold the center. We hold for the kingdom."

"The men are tired, Fredrick," Frederick countered, his eyes scanning the horizon where the sun was beginning to dip, casting long, skeletal shadows across the mud. "They see two kings, and they wonder which one they are dying for. The Council whispers even now—they want a single crown. They want a choice between the 'E' and the 'No E'."

Fredrick turned to his brother, his face a mask of grim determination. "Let them whisper to the wind. Today, there is no 'E' and there is no 'Legal.' There is only the shield at my left hand, which is yours, and the sword at your right, which is mine. If we survive this night, the scholars can argue over the spelling of our graves. Until then, we are one."

The sound of a horn, low and guttural, drifted from the tree line. The House of Garrick was mounting its final charge. Thousands of mercenary boots hammered the earth, a rhythmic thrum that vibrated through the soles of the brothers' boots. It was a sound of inevitable destruction.

"For Alaric-Heim!" Frederick roared, drawing his silvered blade.

"For the Peace that follows!" Fredrick bellowed, stepping forward to meet the wave of steel.

The clash was instantaneous and deafening. The brothers fought not as two men, but as a single machine of war.

When a Garrick pikeman lunged for Frederick's exposed flank, Fredrick's blackened shield was there to intercept, the wood splintering under the impact but the line holding firm. When a mace swung toward Fredrick's helm, Frederick's blade flashed like lightning, parrying the blow and countering with a lethal precision that left the attacker gasping in the mud.

They pushed forward, driving into the heart of the enemy. The "E-Clan" soldiers and the "Legal" soldiers, seeing their twin lords fighting in such perfect, selfless synchronicity, forgot their grievances. For a few hours, the spelling of a name didn't matter—only the survival of the man standing next to them did.

But the cost was climbing. The victory was near, but it was a Pyrrhic one.

As the final Garrick captain fell, a stray volley of archer fire hissed through the darkening sky. Frederick, seeing the shadow of the arrows first, threw himself in front of his brother. Two shafts found their mark in his shoulder and chest. Almost simultaneously, a dying Garrick footman lunged from the mud with a hidden dagger, piercing Fredrick's side as he reached out to catch his falling twin. He immediately contained the situation and focused on saving his beloved brother and self, but their injury was much and there was nothing they nor anyone could do to save them.

"Did... did we hold?" Frederick whispered, his breath hitching.

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"We held," Fredrick replied, his voice a faint rumble. "The ridge is ours. The kingdom... is safe."



The battle ended in a sudden, haunting silence. The enemy fled into the woods, but there was no cheering from the victors.

The soldiers gathered in a wide, solemn circle. In the center of the mud-slicked ridge, the twins lay propped against a shattered wagon wheel. Frederick's silver filigree was dark with gore; Fredrick's blackened steel was dented beyond repair. They held each other's hands, their fingers

interlocking so tightly that no man could tell where one ended and the other began.

"Promise me," Frederick gasped, clutching his brother's hand. "Promise me they won't... they won't tear it apart over a letter. We are... one name."

Fredrick tried to nod, but his strength was fading. "One name. One blood."

As the moon rose over Oakhaven, the Twin Shields grew cold. They died in the same breath, defending a unity that they alone understood.

The tragedy, however, began the moment their bodies were carried back to the capital. The "E-Clan" claimed Frederick died first, making his son the heir. The "Legal" Clan claimed Fredrick lived a moment longer, securing the throne for his line.

Though they shared one face, the midwives of the High Citadel whispered that Fredrick had been the first to enter the world, preceding his brother by a mere handful of minutes. By the laws of the First Charter, that slight window of time made him the actual King. Yet, Fredrick's love for his brother, Frederick, was a force that defied ancient protocols. He viewed their souls as a single tree with two great branches; to elevate one was to diminish the whole.

From the day of their coronation, Fredrick made a choice that stunned the Council of Ricks: he granted Frederick equal royal powers, a move that effectively created a diarchy of absolute devotion. He divided the royal treasury,

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the seals of state, and even the "United Reich" army, allowing Frederick to command his own legions. Gradually, the barracks became distinct enclaves—the indigo-banners of the "E-Clan" and the crimson-banners of the "Legal" Fredricks. Two separate administrations began to pulse within the same walls, until the common folk, watching the two kings ride side-by-side, truly wondered which one held the original crown.



The realm was a masterpiece of shared geography, a land where every bridge and valley belonged to two masters.

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The peace the twins died for vanished with their final breath. The eighty-year struggle had begun, and the "Edict of Unity" was buried with them in the cold, silent earth.

Chapter 2: Shades of the Larch-Wood Siege



The funeral of the Twin Shields was the last time the people of Alaric-Heim shared a single loaf of bread or a single prayer. While the bodies of Fredrick the Steadfast and Frederick the Eloquent were laid in a shared sarcophagus—their stone effigies holding a singular, marble sword—the living were already carving the kingdom into pieces.

The capital city, Oakhaven, was a marvel of medieval engineering, built in concentric circles of white stone and oak. But within a year of the twins' deaths, a new structure began to rise: a wall of polished granite that sliced through the heart of the city, dividing the Great Library from the High Smithies.

On the eastern side stood the House of Frederick, the "E-Clan." Led by the widowed Lady Elara, they claimed that the letter 'E' was the mark of the civilized. To them, the "E" represented the Ecclesiastical right to rule and the Education required to lead. They were the architects, the scribes, and the masters of coin. They began to rewrite the chronicles, dipping their quills in ink that favored the silver-filigreed history of the Eloquent twin.

On the western side remained the House of Fredrick, the "Legal Lineage." Led by the veteran commander Baron Osric, they viewed the "E" as a decadent addition—a vanity that weakened the iron-clad traditions of the first kings. To them, the name Fredrick was a pillar: solid, unyielding, and stripped of unnecessary ornament. They were the keepers

of the grain, the masters of the horse, and the guardians of the borderlands.

The tension reached its breaking point during the Day of the First Tithe, exactly two years after the battle at the ridge.

The Great Hall was cold, the air thick with the smell of tallow candles and damp stone. Baron Osric stood at the head of the long table, his hand resting on the hilt of a heavy, unadorned broadsword. Across from him sat Lady Elara, draped in silks of deep indigo, a golden quill pinned to her bodice like a weapon.



"The records of the Royal Mint must be stamped with the King's name," Osric rumbled, his voice echoing off the vaulted ceiling. "And the King's name, as dictated by the First Charter of the Founders, is F-R-E-D-R-I-C-K. To add

a letter is to forge a signature. It is an act of treason against the blood."

Lady Elara did not flinch. She leaned forward, the candlelight dancing in her eyes. "A name evolves with the soul of its people, Baron. My husband, Frederick, was the voice of this realm. He brought the arts, the trade routes, and the diplomacy that kept the House of Garrick at bay for a decade. To omit the 'E' is to omit his legacy. We will not be erased by your stubborn refusal to adapt."

"It is not adaptation; it is dilution!" Osric slammed his fist onto the table, rattling the pewter goblets. "You build schools while the borders crumble. You spend gold on tapestries while my men sharpen their blades on whetstones because they cannot afford new steel. The Legal Lineage demands the throne, for only a Fredrick has the strength to hold it."

"Then the throne shall remain empty," Elara hissed, standing slowly. "For the House of Frederick will never bow to a man who treats a letter like a casualty of war. From this day forward, we are a separate court. Keep your horses and your grain, Baron. We shall keep the records, the gold, and the law."

That night, the "Great Omission" became official. The E-Clan scribes systematically removed every document from the royal archives that lacked the middle 'E'. In retaliation, Osric's men raided the stone-masons' guild, smashing every commemorative plaque that bore the "corrupted" spelling.



The tragedy was not found in the violence, but in the silence that followed. Families were split at the dinner table. A brother who wished to be a scholar moved East to become a Frederick; a brother who wished to be a knight stayed West to remain a Fredrick.

Decades began to pile up like dead leaves. The high-stakes game of political chess turned into a generational grudge. The fields between the two halves of the city, once used for festivals and markets, became a "No Man's Land" of overgrown brambles and bitter memories. The House of Garrick, watching from the shadows of the northern mountains, grew fat and strong while the "Ricks" grew lean and paranoid.

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By the time eighty years had passed, the origin of the fight was a ghost story told to children. The youth of the E-Clan were taught that the Fredricks were crude barbarians who hated knowledge. The youth of the Legal Lineage were taught that the Fredericks were soft-handed thieves who had stolen the kingdom's wealth with a stroke of a pen.

The kingdom of Alaric-Heim was a body with two heads, each trying to strangle the other, unaware that the heart was beginning to fail as the kingdom to shrink.



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Deep in the outskirts, far from the granite walls and the bickering lords, a young man worked the soil of a small, hidden farm. He was a man of broad shoulders and steady grey eyes—the exact image of the twins who had died eighty years prior. He went by the name his mother had whispered to him on her deathbed, a name he never spoke aloud in the city.

His name was Fredrick. And he wanted nothing to do with the throne.

Chapter 3: Silence of the Empty Dais



The capital of Oakhaven was no longer the jewel of the Midlands; it was a fractured crown rusting in the rain. The Wall of the Suffix—as the locals called the granite divide—had become a jagged scar through the city's heart. To the East, the spires of the Frederick Quarter were peeling their gold leaf; to the West, the barracks of the Fredrick District smelled of damp wool and desperate hunger.

In the Chamber of the Great Hearth, located in the neutral zone of the palace where the wall ended, a fire flickered with the last of the seasoned oak. Two figures sat at a table of ancient cedar, staring at a map of Alaric-Heim that looked more like a funeral shroud.

"The Garrick raiders burned three granaries in the Vale of Rickard last night," rumbled Lord Alaric the Iron-Gray, the eldest statesman of the Legal Lineage. He slammed a heavy, scarred hand onto the parchment. "My scouts report their war-horns can be heard as far south as Brod-Gate. We have no men to send. They are all busy guarding the Wall against your tax collectors, Richard."

Across from him, Chancellor Richard the Gilded, leader of the E-Clan, adjusted his fur-lined cloak. His face was thin, his eyes shadowed by the weight of a treasury that contained more ledgers than coins. "Tax collectors? We haven't collected a copper from the Hendrick Docks in months, Alaric. The merchant ships from the Seas of Edric



won't dock in a city that can't decide which King's face to put on the port entry forms. We are starving in silk robes, while you are starving in iron plates."

"The throne is a vacuum," a sharp voice cut through the gloom.

Lady Frederica, the Chancellor's niece and a woman whose intellect was feared more than any blade, stepped into the light. She carried a heavy vellum scroll. "Our spies in the North-Reach say the House of Garrick prepares a final march. They don't care about the 'E.' They only see a kingdom that has forgotten how to stand. If we do not seat a King within the moon's turn, Alaric-Heim will become a footnote in someone else's history."

"There is no one left," Alaric growled. "Every Frederick you propose is a fop who can't hold a shield, and every Fredrick I propose is a brute who can't read a treaty."

"There is one," Frederica said softly, unrolling the scroll. It was a hidden genealogy from the Monastery of Saint Osrick. "The true blood. The direct descent of Fredrick the Steadfast. He has lived in the Shadow-Woods for twenty years, tucked away in the hamlet of Stone-Brook. His mother was of the High Lineage, but she fled when the riots of the 'Fortieth Year' burned the Summer Palace."

Richard leaned in, his eyes narrowing. "The boy from the woods? I've heard rumors. They say he works the earth like a commoner. He has no courtly training, no political ties. He would be... malleable."

"He would be a puppet," Alaric added, though his eyes sparkled with a different hope. "A Fredrick on the throne would satisfy my generals. We could rule the realm from the war-room while he hunts deer."

"And the 'E' Clan would accept him because he is untainted by our decades of hate," Richard mused. "We tell them he represents a return to 'Essential' power. We can keep him in the library, teaching him his letters, while we manage the gold."

While the lords plotted in the cold palace, thirty miles north in the Shadow-Woods, the air smelled of pine and damp earth.

Fredrick was mid-swing, his axe biting deep into a fallen larch tree. He didn't wear a crown; he wore a tunic of

homespun hemp, stained with sap and sweat. His muscles were corded from years of honest labor, his jaw set with a quiet peace that the men in the city had long forgotten.

"You're over-swinging again, Fred," a voice chirped from the nearby stump.

Fredrick wiped his brow and looked at Derrick, his closest friend and the village blacksmith. Derrick was a man of the "New Rick" blood—tough, pragmatic, and fiercely loyal to the man who helped him forge tools for the village.

"The wood is frozen, Der," Fredrick replied, his voice deep and steady. "It needs a bit of temper. Just like your iron."

"Word reached the village market today," Derrick said, his tone turning serious. "The King's Heralds were spotted on the Old King's Road. They aren't looking for taxes this time. They're looking for a face. A face that looks like the statues in the town square."

Fredrick went still. He looked at his hands—calloused, scarred, and earth-stained. "Let them look. I'm a woodcutter of Stone-Brook. I have no interest in their stone walls or their silver quills. My mother's last wish was for me to stay in the shade, where the sun can't burn me."

"The shade is shrinking, Fred," Derrick warned, pointing north. "The smoke from the Garrick raids is visible from the high ridge. If the city falls, Stone-Brook is next. You can't hide from blood, especially when it's the kind that kings want to drink."



Fredrick looked toward the horizon, where the distant spires of Oakhaven pierced the gray clouds. He felt a strange ache in his chest—not of ambition, but of a heavy, ancestral duty he had spent his life trying to outrun.

"I am a man of peace, Derrick," Fredrick said, his grip tightening on the axe handle. "And the city is a place of war."

"Maybe," Derrick replied, "that's exactly why they're coming for you."

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Before Fredrick could respond, the sound of galloping hooves shattered the silence of the woods. A company of riders in the split colors of the realm—blue for the 'E' and red for the 'Legal'—burst into the clearing. At the head was Lady Frederica and Lord Alaric, their faces pale with the shock of seeing their legend in the flesh.

They didn't see a puppet. They saw a King who looked like he could uproot a mountain.

"Fredrick of Stone-Brook," Frederica announced, her voice trembling despite her resolve. "The Dais is empty. The Kingdom is dying. By the laws of the First Twins, we have come to bring you home."

Fredrick didn't bow. He didn't even drop his axe. He simply looked at the "E" on Frederica's cloak and the "No E" on Alaric's shield and felt the weight of eighty years of spite crashing down upon his shoulders.

"I have a home," Fredrick said. "Go back to your walls."

Lord Alaric dismounted, his heavy boots crunching the frost-dusted pine needles. He didn't look like a nobleman coming to claim a prize; he looked like a man who had stared into a furnace and realized he was made of wax.

"The walls are crumbling, woodcutter," Alaric said, his voice like grinding stones. "Garrick's 'Shatterers' aren't just burning granaries. They are burning the very idea of us. They know that as long as we fight over a letter, we are too weak to fight them."

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Lady Frederica stepped forward, her silk cloak snagging on a bramble—a sharp contrast to the rugged utility of the forest. "Fredrick, please. You speak of home, but what is a home when the kingdom that shelters it is being hollowed out? You see the 'E' on my chest as a symbol of pride, but right now, it is a target. Our people are dying because we have no center. We have no one who can speak to both sides without a sneer."



Fredrick turned back to the larch tree, his knuckles white around the handle of his axe. "And you think a crown will change that? You want a face for your statues. You want a

name to sign your papers. But look at my hands." He held them out—calloused, stained with the dark blood of the forest, scarred by the bite of the winter cold. "These hands were made for building, not for ruling over men who hate each other for how they spell 'Peace'."

Derrick, who had been watching from his stump with a blacksmith's watchful eye, stood up. He walked to Fredrick's side, his presence a grounded shadow. "They're right about one thing, Fred. The market in Stone-Brook was empty today. No flour. No salt. Even the iron I use for your axes is being seized by 'Legal' patrols to make pike-heads that never reach the front because the 'E' lords block the roads."

Fredrick looked at his friend. "You too, Der?"

"I'm just a man who knows a broken hinge when he sees one," Derrick replied softly. "You can keep swinging that axe until the forest is flat, but it won't stop the smoke from rising over the horizon. Eventually, the fire will reach Stone-Brook."

Alaric stepped closer, ignoring the defensive tilt of Fredrick's shoulders. "We didn't come here to offer you a throne of gold, boy. We came to offer you a throne of thorns. The Council is a vipers' nest. Richard is counting his last coins, and my generals are ready to march on the Frederick Quarter just to steal their grain. If you don't come, the 'United Reich' becomes a graveyard before the month is out."

Frederica's eyes softened, losing their courtly edge. "We saw you from the ridge before we rode down. We saw how you moved. You don't strike the wood with anger; you strike it with rhythm. You understand the temper of the material. Alaric-Heim is the wood, Fredrick. It is frozen, brittle, and ready to snap. We need the man who knows how to find the grain."

Fredrick looked at the two leaders—the warrior and the diplomat—standing together in the dirt of his workspace. For the first time, he saw the exhaustion behind their titles. They weren't just lords; they were survivors who had run out of options.

He looked up at the sky, where the sun was beginning to dip, casting long, twin shadows of the larch trees across the clearing. The silence of the woods felt different now—less like peace and more like a held breath.

"If I go," Fredrick said, his voice dropping to a low rumble that seemed to vibrate in the very earth, "I don't go as an 'E' or a 'No-E'. I don't go to sit on a chair and listen to men argue about suffixes. If I go, I go to build a bridge. And when a bridge is built, people have to walk across it. Do you understand what that means? It means you will have to stand on the same side as the people you've spent eighty years cursing."

Alaric and Frederica exchanged a long look. It was a silent negotiation, a final surrender of the old ways.

"We understand," Frederica whispered.

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Fredrick let out a long, slow breath that turned to mist in the air. He turned to the larch tree one last time and delivered a final, massive blow. The tree groaned and fell, a clean, perfect cut that shook the ground.

He didn't pick up his cloak. He didn't gather his things. He simply handed the axe to Derrick.



"Keep it sharp, Der," Fredrick said. "I might need it if the pens don't work."

He walked past the horses, past the armored guards who stared at him in hushed awe, and began the long trek toward

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the Old King's Road. He didn't look back at his cabin. He looked toward the smoke on the horizon, his jaw set, his pace steady.

The Woodcutter was gone. The King was coming.

Part II:

The Woodcutter's Court

- **Chapter 4: The Woodcutter of Alaric-Heim –**
Fredrick's forced arrival at the capital and his first meeting with the bickering lords.
- **Chapter 5: Whispers of the Council of Cunning –**
The lords attempt to sabotage the new King with complex ledgers and linguistic traps.
- **Chapter 6: The Unwilling Anointing –**
Fredrick's first act of power: dismantling the Wall to build the granaries.

Chapter 4: The Woodcutter of Alaric-Heim



The journey from the Shadow-Woods to the capital was not a parade; it was a forced march. Fredrick rode at the center of a steel-clad escort, his woodsman's tunic a stark contrast to the polished plate of the knights. He felt less like a King and more like a captured beast being hauled to a menagerie.

As they passed through the Gates of Theodoric, the "Ruler of the People" archway that marked the city's entrance, Fredrick saw the true face of his kingdom. The people were gaunt, their eyes hollowed by decades of the "E" and "No-



E" conflict. They stood in the gutters of Didrick Street, watching him with a mixture of hope and weary cynicism.

"They look to you for a miracle, Fredrick," Lady Frederica whispered, riding close to his side. Her eyes were sharp, calculating the political value of every cheer from the crowd. "Give them a smile. A King should look like he enjoys his crown."

"A King should look like he understands his people," Fredrick replied, his gaze fixed on a shoeless child huddled in a doorway. "I see no joy in this city. Only a long, slow rot."

They arrived at the Great Citadel of Alaric, the fortress meant to represent the "Ruler of All." Here, the Council had gathered in the Chamber of the Gilded 'E'. The air was thick with the scent of expensive incense and the sour smell of old grudges.

As Fredrick stepped into the hall, the assembly rose. It was a sea of "Ricks" and "Riches," each representing a branch of the splintered dynasty.

At the head of the table sat Richard the Stern, the "Brave Ruler." Beside him stood his daughter, Ricarda, a woman whose "Strong Power" was evident in the way she gripped the hilt of her ceremonial longsword. To her left was Ulrick the Elder, the "Noble Ruler" of the northern territories, his face a map of white scars, accompanied by his niece Ulrica, the "Noble Power" who managed the vast estates of the West.

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"So," Richard barked, his voice echoing off the vaulted stone. "The woodcutter has arrived. He has the face of the twins, certainly. But does he have the stomach for the throne?"



"He has the stomach to work a full day, which is more than I can say for half this room," Fredrick said, his voice level and resonant. He did not bow. He walked to the center of the room and stood before the empty, massive throne of oak and iron.

Alaric the Iron-Gray stepped forward. "We have brought you here to end the deadlock. The House of Frederick and the House of Fredrick cannot agree on a law, a tax, or a

border. You are the 'True Blood.' You will wear the crown, and you will sign the decrees we present to you."

"I am a Fredrick," the woodcutter said, turning to face them. "But I am not a fool. You want a name to put on your parchment so you can continue your bickering under a royal seal."

A tall, lean man with a face like a hawk stepped from the shadows. This was Emeric, the "Work Ruler," the man in charge of the city's labor and infrastructure. Beside him was Emery, the "Industrious Ruler" of the weaver's guild.

"The mills are silent, Fredrick," Emeric said, his voice tight. "The workers of the Emmerick District refuse to weave the banners of the 'E' Clan, and the 'Legal' Clan refuses to pay for the 'E' Clan's silk. We need a King who will put the kingdom back to work."

"And we need the tithes!" called out Edric, the "Wealthy Ruler," his fingers twitching toward the heavy gold chains around his neck. "The treasury of the Edric Bank is a tomb. Without a King to guarantee the loans, trade with the Hendrick Docks will vanish."

The room erupted.

Bardrick, the "Axe Ruler" and captain of the royal guard, slammed the butt of his poleaxe into the floor. "Silence! The King has not spoken!"

Fredrick looked at the faces around the table. He saw Audric, the "Wise Ruler," nodding slowly from his chair, his old eyes seeing through the greed of the younger lords.

He saw Kenrick, the "Bold Ruler" of the scouts, leaning against a pillar with a smirk that suggested he was waiting for Fredrick to fail. He saw Waldrick, the "Bright Ruler" of the scholars, holding a quill as if it were a dagger.

"You speak of gold, of labor, of silk, and of titles," Fredrick said, his voice rising until it commanded the room. "But none of you have spoken of the House of Garrick. Their fires are visible from the Stone-Brook ridge. While you argue over whether a letter belongs in a name, a real enemy prepares to erase the name entirely."

"We have a plan for the defense—" Roderick, the "Famous Ruler" of the city heralds, began, but Fredrick cut him off.

"A plan? You have two armies that won't march together. You have a wall that cuts your own throat. I did not ask for this crown. I do not want it. But if I am to sit on that throne, I will not be your puppet."

He turned to Cedric, the "Bounty Ruler" who managed the royal granaries, and his wife Cedrica, the "Gifted Ruler" of the healers. "Cedric, how much grain is left in the 'Legal' stores?"

"Enough for a month, Sire," Cedric stammered.

"And Cedrica, how many bandages in the 'E' hospitals?"

"We are well-stocked, but we do not treat the 'Legal' soldiers," she said, her voice dropping.

Fredrick looked at Richard and Alaric. "Tomorrow, the 'E' hospitals will treat the woodcutters, and the 'Legal' grain

will feed the scribes. If a single man refuses, he will answer to me. Not as a King, but as a man who knows how to fell a tree that has gone rotten at the core."

The silence that followed was heavy with shock. Ricarda let out a short, sharp laugh, her hand shifting from her sword to her hip. "The woodcutter has teeth," she whispered to Ulrica.

"The E-Clan will never agree to share their medicine," Richard growled. "It is our 'Essential' right."

"And the Fredricks will not give their wheat to those who look down upon them!" Alaric added.

"Then you have chosen your graves," Fredrick said, turning toward the door. "I am going back to the woods. You can stay here and debate the spelling of your epitaphs."

"Wait!" Audric, the wise ruler, stood up, his voice thin but commanding. "He is the first 'Rick' in eighty years to speak the truth. He doesn't want the power, which is why he must have it. Lord Richard, Baron Alaric... sign the temporary decree. Let the 'E' and the 'No-E' work together for one week. If he fails, we send him back. If he succeeds..."

The lords looked at each other. They saw the logic of a man who had nothing to lose. They believed that in one week, Fredrick would be so overwhelmed by the "Work" of Emeric and the "Wealth" of Edric that he would beg to be their puppet.

"One week," Richard hissed. "One week of this... 'Unity'."

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Fredrick stopped at the door. He didn't smile. He knew the "E" Clan was hoping he would run, and the "Legal" Clan was hoping they could rule from behind him. He looked at the throne one last time.

"Tomorrow," Fredrick said, "we begin the work of the Edict of Unity. And Hendrick, make sure my quarters are humble. I find the smell of palace silk reminds me too much of a shroud."

Chapter 5: Whispers of the Council of Cunning



The week began not with a roar of trumpets, but with the scratching of a hundred quills and the sharpening of a thousand daggers. The Great Citadel of Alaric felt like a pressure cooker. Fredrick had moved his quarters from the silk-lined royal chambers to a spartan room in the Hendrick Tower, the "Ruler of the Home" watch-post that overlooked both sides of the Wall.

By the third dawn, the sabotage began. It was subtle, designed to make the "Peace Ruler" look like a fool who couldn't manage a village, let alone a kingdom.

In the Hall of Records, Roderick, the "Famous Ruler" of the heralds, was orchestrating a linguistic nightmare. Every public notice he posted used a chaotic blend of spellings—Frederik, Frederyk, Fredric—designed to incite brawls in the marketplaces.

"The people need to know who their King is," Roderick said with a sleek, oily smile as Fredrick entered the hall. "But if I choose one spelling, I offend half the city. If I choose the other, I start a riot. I'm simply being... thorough."

Fredrick walked to the wall and ripped down a notice. "You aren't being thorough, Roderick. You're being famous for your indecision. From this moment, every decree will bear no name at all. Only the Seal of the Twin Shields. If the

people see the shield, they know it is the King's word. The spelling can wait for the peace."

Roderick's smile faltered. His "Famous" influence relied on the drama of the name; Fredrick had just removed the weapon from his hand.

But the real threat lay in the South-Yard, where the military was being pushed to a breaking point. Kenrick, the "Bold Ruler" of the scouts, and Bardrick, the "Axe Ruler," were in the middle of a heated standoff.

"My scouts will not report to a 'Legal' captain!" Kenrick spat, his hand on his belt-knife. He was young, arrogant, and built for speed. "We are the eyes of the E-Clan. We don't take orders from men who think 'strategy' is just hitting something harder with an axe."

Bardrick, a mountain of a man with arms like oak trunks, took a step forward. "And my guardsmen won't bleed for a scout who spends more time grooming his horse than practicing his forms. If the 'E' soldiers want to lead, let them find their own steel."

Fredrick stepped into the yard. The tension was a physical weight. "Kenrick. Bardrick. Stand down."

"The 'Bold' one here thinks he's above the law," Bardrick growled.

"I am the law!" Kenrick barked.



Fredrick walked between them. He was unarmed, yet he held himself with a gravity that made the soldiers go quiet. "Kenrick, you are bold. You see things others miss. Bardrick, you are the axe. You hold what others lose. Tell me, if the House of Garrick attacks the Brod-Gate tonight, who dies first?"

Neither man spoke.

"The scout dies first because he has no shield to back him," Fredrick said, his voice dropping to a dangerous low. "And the guardsman dies second because he didn't see the enemy

coming until they were at his throat. You aren't two armies. You are two halves of a corpse."

He turned to Kenrick. "You will take three of Bardrick's men on every patrol. You will teach them how to see the shadow in the grass." He turned to Bardrick. "You will take three of Kenrick's scouts and teach them how to hold a line when the ground turns to blood. If I see a patrol that is not 'Mixed,' I will strip the 'Rick' from your names myself and send you to the mines with Emeric."

As Fredrick walked away, he felt a pair of eyes on his back. Ricarda, the "Strong Power," was watching from the battlements, her arms crossed. She wasn't sneering like the others; she was studying him.

That evening, the council reconvened. The table was a minefield.

Edric, the "Wealthy Ruler," slammed a ledger down. "The 'Legal' farmers in the Vale of Rickard refuse to sell their grain to the E-Clan merchants! They claim the 'E' coin is debased. We are three days from a bread riot."

"And the 'E' Clan healers under Cedrica have locked the infirmaries!" Ulrick the Noble shouted. "They claim my knights are 'unclean' and 'uncultured.' My men are dying of infected wounds from the last skirmish!"

Fredrick stood up. He didn't look tired; he looked like a man who had finally found the knot he needed to cut.

"Emeric," Fredrick called out. The "Work Ruler" looked up. "You complain that the mills are silent. Emery, you say

the weavers have no wool. Cedric, you say the grain is rotting in the fields."

"The logistics are impossible, Sire!" Emeric complained. "The Fredricks won't work for the Fredericks!"

"Then we change the work," Fredrick said. He pulled a map of the city toward him. "The Wall of the Suffix. That granite eyesore that divides our streets."

A silence fell over the room. Alaric and Richard leaned in, their eyes narrowed.

"The Wall is the foundation of our defense," Richard said cautiously.

"The Wall is the tombstone of your kingdom," Fredrick countered. "Tomorrow at dawn, Emeric, you will take the 'Legal' stonemasons. Emery, you will take the 'E' laborers. You will start at the North Gate. You will not build. You will dismantle."

"Dismantle the Wall?" Ulrick gasped. "That's eighty years of history!"

"That's eighty years of rubble," Fredrick corrected. "The stone from the Wall will be used to build a new granary in the Vale of Rickard—a shared one. And Edric, you will provide the gold to pay the workers, but here is the catch: every pay-chit must be co-signed by a man from the opposite clan. No co-signature, no coin."

"They'll kill each other before they sign," Roderick whispered, his "Famous" instincts sensing a bloodbath.

"Then they don't get paid," Fredrick said simply. "And Cedrica, your hospitals will be opened to everyone by noon, or I will move the royal grain stores into your wards. Let's see how 'Essential' your healing is when you have no bread to eat while you perform it."

The council sat in stunned silence. They had expected a woodcutter they could confuse with ledgers and lineages. Instead, they had a King who was treating the kingdom like a forest—clearing the brush so the trees could finally grow.

As the meeting broke up, Audric, the "Old Ruler," lingered behind. "You are playing a dangerous game, Fredrick. You are taking away their pride. Men will die for their pride long before they die for their country."

"I'm not taking their pride, Audric," Fredrick said, looking out the window at the dark city. "I'm giving them a choice. They can be proud and dead, or they can be 'Ricks' and live. But tell me... where is Ulrica? The Noble Power hasn't spoken a word all night."

Audric's eyes clouded. "She is with Alarice, the other 'Ruler of All.' They are in the vaults. They aren't worried about the grain, Fredrick. They are worried about the Garrick Scouts that were spotted at the Old King's Bridge an hour ago."

Fredrick's heart hammered against his ribs. The sabotage from within was nothing compared to the storm coming from without.

"The bridge is only ten miles away," Fredrick whispered. "If the Wall comes down tomorrow, we are exposed."

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"Exactly," a new voice said. Ricarda stepped into the light, her hand on her sword. "So, the question is, King Fredrick... can you make us love each other faster than the House of Garrick can kill us?"

Chapter 6: The Unwilling Anointing



The dawn broke cold and grey over Oakhaven, the light struggling to pierce a thick mist that rolled off the River Edric. In the center of the city, the Wall of the Suffix stood like a jagged, granite tooth.

By the first hour of light, a massive crowd had gathered. On the West side stood the Fredrick laborers, led by Emeric, their heavy iron sledges resting on their shoulders. On the East side stood the Frederick stonemasons, led by Emery, their fine chisels and measuring lines ready. They glared at one another across a ten-foot gap of "No Man's Land."



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Fredrick stood atop a wooden platform built against the granite. He looked down at the two factions. Beside him stood Bardrick, clutching his great-axe, and Kenrick, whose scouts were nervously scanning the northern horizon.

"Today, we do not destroy a wall," Fredrick's voice boomed, carrying through the damp air. "We harvest the stone to build a future. Emeric, strike the first blow. Emery, guide the fall."

For a heartbeat, no one moved. The air was thick with eighty years of hesitation. Then, Emeric—the "Work Ruler"—stepped forward. He looked at Emery. The two had been rivals for decades, competing for the same royal contracts that never came. Emeric raised his sledge and swung.

The sound of iron meeting stone cracked through the city like a thunderclap. A shard of granite flew. Emery immediately stepped in, using a crowbar to lever the loosened block. Together, the "Work" and the "Industry" of the realm moved the first stone.

As the block hit the dirt, a cheer didn't go up. Instead, a low, haunting sound drifted from the northern battlements.

Hoooooooo-unnnn.

The horn of the House of Garrick.

"They're here," Kenrick hissed, his "Bold" eyes widening. "They aren't waiting for the moon's turn. They've bypassed

the Old King's Bridge by fording the shallows at Hendrick's Leap!"

"How many?" Fredrick demanded, stepping off the platform.

"A vanguard of five hundred heavy horse," Kenrick reported. "And a main host of four thousand footmen following behind. They'll be at the North Gate within the hour."

The crowd below began to panic. The "E" Clan merchants started to flee toward the eastern vaults, while the "Legal" farmers scrambled for their pitchforks. The fragile unity of the morning was shattering before the first wall-stone could even be cleared.

"The North Gate is weak!" Alaric the Iron-Gray shouted, riding into the square. "The 'E' Clan neglected the portcullis for years! It won't hold a ram!"

"Because the 'Legal' Clan stole the timber meant for its bracing!" Richard the Gilded countered, his face pale.

"Enough!" Fredrick roared. He turned to Bardrick. "Captain, take every man who can hold a shield to the North Gate. I don't care if they spell their name with an 'E' or a drop of blood. If that gate falls, there will be no names left to argue over."

He then looked to Ulrica, the "Noble Power," and Ricarda, the "Strong Power." They were standing together near the armory, their faces grim.

"Ulrica, you know the archives. Where is the Aethelric Oil? The ancient stores of pitch?"

"In the lower vaults of the Frederick Quarter," Ulrica answered. "But the 'Legal' guards won't let us through the tunnels."

"They will now," Fredrick said. He turned to Alaric. "Give her your signet. Now!"

As the city scrambled into a chaotic defense, Fredrick realized the gravity of his position. He was a King of a city that didn't know how to fight as one. He ran toward the North Gate, his boots thumping on the cobblestones.

He arrived to find Bardrick struggling to organize a line. The "Legal" knights were forming a shield wall, but the "E" archers were stationed too far back, refusing to take orders from a man they considered a "No-E" brute.

"The Garrick rams are hitting the timbers!" Bardrick yelled over the din of crashing wood. "We can't hold the gatehouse if we don't have archer cover on the battlements!"

Fredrick looked up. The "E" archers were hesitating. He didn't shout. He didn't threaten. He grabbed a discarded bow from the dirt, stepped into the line of fire on the walkway, and loosed an arrow at the approaching Garrick line.

"I am a woodcutter!" Fredrick screamed up at the archers. "I know how to aim! Are the scholars of the East going to

let a man from the woods show them how to defend their own library? Aim for the gaps in the plate! Fire!"

Inspired by the sight of their King in the teeth of the storm, the "E" archers loosed a volley. The sky hissed with cloth-yard shafts. The Garrick ram slowed as the men Manning it fell.

But the North Gate groaned. A massive crack appeared in the center oak.

"The brace is snapping!" Kenrick shouted from the gate-level.

Fredrick looked at the pile of granite they had just dismantled from the Wall. "The stones! Emeric! Emery! Get the laborers! Forget the granary! Bring the granite blocks to the North Gate! We'll block the entrance from the inside!"

It was a desperate, back-breaking task. For the first time in eighty years, the muscles of the Fredricks and the Fredericks strained against the same weight. They hauled the massive granite blocks—the very stones that had divided them—and piled them against the fracturing gate.

As the Garrick ram finally smashed through the wood, it didn't find an open road into the city. It found a solid, immovable wall of "Unity Stone."

The enemy halted, confused. From atop the gate, Ricarda and Ulrica appeared, leading a team of healers and oil-bearers. They poured the pitch down onto the stalled ram,

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and at Fredrick's command, the archers loosed flaming arrows.

The North Gate became a wall of fire. The Garrick vanguard recoiled, their horses screaming as they retreated from the heat.

The city went silent, save for the crackling of the flames. The laborers, the knights, the scholars, and the lords stood in the soot-stained square. They looked at the pile of stones blocking the gate—stones that had come from the Wall of the Suffix.



Fredrick stood at the center, his face blackened by smoke, his hemp tunic singed. He looked at Richard and Alaric.

"The Wall didn't protect you," Fredrick said, his voice rasping. "It only gave the enemy a place to trap you. Today, the 'E' and the 'No-E' saved this city. But the main host is still out there."

Audric the Wise stepped forward, his eyes wet with tears. He knelt in the mud and the soot. "The King is anointed," he whispered. "Not with oil, but with the sweat of his people."

One by one, the "Ricks" of Alaric-Heim fell to their knees. Richard, Alaric, Emeric, Edric, Bardrick, and Kenrick. Even Ricarda sheathed her sword and bowed her head

"We are at your command, King Fredrick," Alaric said. "Tell us how to break the siege."

Fredrick looked at the flickering fires. He didn't feel like a King. He felt the crushing weight of four thousand lives resting on his shoulders.

"We don't break the siege by hiding," Fredrick said. "We break it by showing them that the two-headed beast has finally found its heart. Kenrick, find me a messenger. We are going to send a word to the House of Garrick. And that word will be spelled only one way."

The fires at the North Gate transitioned from a roaring inferno to a steady, smoldering orange, casting long shadows across the square. The silence that followed was not one of peace, but of a kingdom holding its breath, waiting for the first command of a man who had only ever commanded trees and iron.

Fredrick looked at the gathered leaders—men and women who had spent their lives building walls of stone and walls of grammar. He saw the soot on Lady Frederica's fine silk and the blood on Lord Alaric's battered plate. For the first time, they looked like the same people.

"Kenrick," Fredrick called out. The young scout stepped forward, his arrogance replaced by a sharp, focused alertness.

"Sire?"

"You said the Garrick host is camped at the Vale of Rickard. They expect us to be cowering behind our 'E's and our 'No-E's. They expect a city of scholars and warriors who can't agree on the name of the ground they stand on." Fredrick turned to Audric the Wise. "Bring me a parchment. Not the fine vellum of the court, but the heavy, rough grain used for military orders. And bring me the Great Seal."

A table was brought into the center of the muddy square. The lords gathered around, their breath misting in the cold dawn. Audric laid out the parchment, his hands trembling.

"What shall we write, my King?" the old scholar asked. "Shall we list our grievances? Shall we cite the ancient treaties of the First Twins?"

"No," Fredrick said, his voice hard. "Garrick the Vile does not care for treaties. He cares for weakness. We will send him a single word. A message that tells him the civil war ended the moment his ram touched our gate."

Fredrick took the quill. He didn't hold it with the delicate grace of a chancellor; he gripped it like the handle of his axe. He dipped it into the black ink and, with a steady, deliberate hand, wrote a single word in massive, block letters that filled the center of the page:

ALRIC

A murmur went through the crowd. Richard the Stern leaned forward, his brow furrowed. "Alric? But... that is the root of both our houses. It is the name of the First Founder before the 'E' was added by the scholars or the 'K' was hardened by the generals. It is... unfinished."



"It is not unfinished," Fredrick countered, looking Richard in the eye. "It is the core. In the ancient tongue, Al meant 'All' and Ric meant 'Ruler.' By stripping away the 'E' that Richard's line prizes and the 'K' that Alaric's line demands, we return to the source. We are telling Garrick that we have burned away the fluff and the pride. We are no longer a collection of suffixes. We are the All-Ruler."

He picked up the heavy gold seal of the realm. On one side was the 'E' of the Gilded Clan, and on the reverse was the 'Rick' of the Iron Lineage. Normally, the King would choose one side to press into the wax to show which faction held favor.

Fredrick did neither.

He called for a hammer. Emeric, the woodcutter's friend, handed him a heavy smith's mallet. Fredrick placed the seal on its side, the thin edge resting against the hot red wax he had dripped onto the parchment. With one sharp, powerful strike, he drove the edge of the seal into the wax, leaving a deep, vertical scar that cut through the center of the emblem.

"The 'E' is the Bridge," Fredrick declared, echoing the words he would later say at the Twin Shadows. "The 'Rick' is the Pillar. But the strike is the Will. Send this to Garrick. Tell his messenger that if he wishes to see the rest of the word, he must come and take it from the tip of our spears."

Kenrick took the parchment, his eyes wide with the realization of the psychological blow they were about to deal. To a conqueror like Garrick, a long, flowery letter of

defiance was expected. A single, ancient root-word, sealed with a scar, was an omen. It told him that the internal rot he relied on had been cauterized.

"And one more thing," Fredrick added as Kenrick mounted his horse. "Tell him the Woodcutter has finished his chores in the forest. Now, I'm coming to clear the weeds from my valley."

As the scout galloped out of the charred North Gate, a new sound began to rise from the square. It wasn't the rhythmic "RICK! RICK!" of the later battles, but a low, humming chant of the ancient name: "Al-Ric... Al-Ric... Al-Ric..."

The two-headed beast had indeed found its heart.

Fredrick turned to Alaric and Richard. "Organize the men. Put the archers on the 'Legal' horses and give the 'E' healers the 'Legal' shields. We march at midday. We will meet them at the Old King's Bridge, where the river is deepest."

"But Sire," Ricarda said, her hand on her sword, "the men haven't slept. They are exhausted."

"Then they can sleep in a free kingdom tomorrow," Fredrick replied, picking up his axe. "Today, we work."

Part III:

The Peace Ruler's Gambit

- **Chapter 7: The Weight of the Unspoken Silent Throne**

—

Fredrick's first week of rule, where his refusal to speak drives the clans to a state of self-reflective anxiety.

- **Chapter 8: Law of the Twin Shadows —**

The introduction of the first Edict: no law can exist without two hands on a single quill.

- **Chapter 9: Fire and Filigree of the Gilded 'E' —**

A dramatic confrontation where Fredrick rejects a bribe of gold, proving his loyalty is to the people, not the "Riches."

Chapter 7: The Weight of the Unspoken Silent Throne



The first week of Fredrick's reign was not marked by a coronation feast or the shouting of new taxes. Instead, it was defined by a terrifying, hollow silence.

Every morning, at the chime of the seventh bell, Fredrick would enter the Chamber of the Gilded 'E'. He wore his simple woodcutter's tunic, now cleaned but still smelling of cedar and pine. He would climb the steps of the dais and sit upon the massive throne of oak and iron. And then, he would do nothing.

He did not speak. He did not nod. He did not sign the piles of parchment that Richard the Gilded and Alaric the Iron-Gray placed before him. He simply sat, his grey eyes moving slowly from face to face, watching the "Ricks" of the realm squirm in their silk and plate.

By the fourth day, the tension in the room was thick enough to choke a horse.

"Your Majesty," Roderick, the "Famous Ruler," began, his voice echoing nervously off the high vaults. "The people of the East are asking for your stance on the Maritime Tax. They need to know if the 'E' in 'Freight' is to be taxed at the royal rate or the merchant rate. A word, Sire? Just a single 'Yes' or 'No'?"

Fredrick stared at him. He didn't blink. Roderick wiped sweat from his brow and stepped back, retreating into the shadows of the pillars.

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"This is a farce!" Richard hissed to Alaric in the corner of the room. "He's a simpleton. We brought a mute to the throne. He doesn't understand the ledgers."

"He understands enough to make you look like a babbling fool, Richard," Ricarda, the "Strong Power," whispered, her hand resting on her sword. She was the only one who seemed to enjoy the silence; she watched Fredrick with a growing, predatory respect.

By the sixth day, the clans were turning on each other out of sheer anxiety. Without a King to tell them what to do, they began to guess his "silent decrees."

"He looked at me when I mentioned the border patrols," Kenrick the Bold argued in the hallway. "He wants the 'Legal' scouts to withdraw. It was in his eyes!"



"Nonsense!" Ulrica the Noble countered. "He looked at the window toward the granaries. He wants the 'E' Clan to take over the distribution. His silence is a test of our initiative!"

The lords began to bribe one another for information they didn't have. They stayed up late into the night, analyzing the way Fredrick shifted his weight or the way he looked at a particular tapestry. They were driving themselves mad. They had spent eighty years fighting over a letter, and now, faced with a man who used no letters at all, they were losing their grip on power.

On the seventh night, the "Council of Cunning" met in secret.

"He's waiting for something," Audric the Wise told the frustrated lords. "He isn't silent because he is empty. He is silent because he is a mirror. He is showing you that without a King to fight over, you have no idea who you are."

"We need a decree," Alaric growled. "The House of Garrick is moving in the North. We cannot lead an army with a King who won't even say 'Good morning'."

The door to the secret chamber creaked open. Fredrick stood there, silhouetted by a single torch. He hadn't come to listen; he had come to end the game.

"You want my voice?" Fredrick said, his first words in seven days cutting through the room like a cold wind. "Tomorrow at dawn, you shall have it. But be warned: a woodcutter only speaks when he is ready to swing the axe."

Chapter 8: Law of the Twin Shadows



The dawn broke over a city held in a collective bated breath. The Council was summoned not to the palace, but to the Great Courtyard, exactly where the granite Wall of the Suffix met the royal cobblestones.

Two desks had been placed in the center of the yard. On one desk lay the "Legal" Ledger of the Fredricks. On the other, the "High" Register of the Fredericks.

Fredrick stood between them. In his hand, he held a single, long quill made from the feather of a mountain hawk.

"For eighty years," Fredrick began, his voice steady and projecting to the thousands of citizens watching from the battlements, "you have used ink to bleed this kingdom dry. You have written laws that favor the 'E' and decrees that favor the 'Legal,' as if a name could be divided and still hold its meaning."

He signaled to Emeric and Emery. The two men stepped forward, representing the labor of both clans.

"From this hour," Fredrick announced, "there is a new law. I call it the Law of the Twin Shadows. Because a man cannot walk without his shadow, so too shall the Houses of this realm never walk alone again."

He held up the hawk quill.

"Every law, every tax, every death warrant, and every merchant's charter will henceforth require two signatures.

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One from the House of Frederick, and one from the House of Fredrick. But they shall not use two pens."

He looked at Richard and Alaric.

"You two will be the first. You will sit at this table. You will grasp this single quill together. Your hands must touch. Your intent must be one. If the signatures do not match perfectly, the law is void and the parchment shall be burned."

"Touch him?" Alaric barked, looking at Richard as if he were a leper. "I would sooner touch a hot iron!"

"Then the soldiers under your command will go unpaid," Fredrick said simply. "And Richard, if you do not sign, the ships in your harbor will be seized and their sails burned to keep the 'Legal' peasants warm. The quill is in the center. The choice is yours."

The crowd watched in stunned silence. The "Brave Ruler" and the "Gilded Ruler" approached the desk like two dogs about to fight over a bone. They sat. Their hands trembled with rage.

Slowly, Richard's thin, ring-covered fingers reached for the quill. Alaric's thick, calloused hand moved to meet it. When their skin touched, a visible shudder went through both men.

They struggled. The quill wobbled. The first signature was a blotched mess.

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"Burn it," Fredrick commanded. Bardrick stepped forward and threw the parchment into a brazier.

"Again," Fredrick said.

They sat for three hours. The sun rose higher. The sweat poured down their faces. They had to coordinate their breathing. They had to synchronize the pressure of their fingers. They had to look into each other's eyes to see when to turn the stroke of the 'R' and when to finish the 'K.'

Finally, a perfect, singular signature appeared on the Edict of Grain Distribution.

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A cheer went up from the battlements—not because the law was signed, but because for the first time in a century, the two leaders had been forced to acknowledge the existence of the other.

"The Twin Shadows have moved," Fredrick said, taking the parchment. "Now, Edric and Hendrick, you are next. The treasury ledgers await."

Chapter 9: Fire and Filigree of the Gilded 'E'



While the Law of the Twin Shadows began to take hold in the streets, a darker plot was brewing in the private garden of Lord Frederick the Younger, a distant cousin of the E-Clan who believed Fredrick's "Unity" was a threat to his personal fortune.

He requested a private audience with the King, claiming he had found a "Sacred Relic" of the original twins.

Fredrick met him in the Solar of Saint Osrick. The room was filled with the scent of lilies and expensive wine. Frederick the Younger bowed low, his silk robes rustling.

"Your Majesty," the lord purred. "This 'Unity' is a noble goal. But we both know that a King need... resources. The Fredricks are crude men. They don't appreciate the finer things. I have here a gift."

He opened a velvet-lined box. Inside was a crown, not of iron or oak, but of solid gold, encrusted with emeralds arranged in the shape of a massive, shimmering 'E'.

"It is the Gilded E," the lord whispered. "The symbol of our clan's true wealth. It is worth more than ten of the 'Legal' granaries. Take it. Wear it. Favor our house in the next trade decree, and I can ensure your 'Peace' is very, very comfortable. You could retire to a palace in the South and never have to look at a woodcutter's axe again."

Edict of Unity. UBI Fredrick

Fredrick looked at the crown. The emeralds caught the light, casting green shadows across his face.

"You call this a gift?" Fredrick asked, his voice dangerously soft.

"A kingly gift, Sire! 'Riches' for the greatest 'Rick'.

Fredrick picked up the crown. It was heavy—cold and lifeless. He walked to the window, which overlooked the square where Emeric and Emery were still working together to move stones.

"You think I want 'Riches'?" Fredrick asked. "I have spent my life watching the seasons change. I have seen the way a forest thrives when every tree has enough light. You offer



me a crown of dead metal and ask me to starve half my forest so you can feel superior."

"I... I only meant—"

Fredrick turned, his eyes flashing with a sudden, regal fury. "You offer me a bribe of gold to betray a man's blood. You think the 'E' makes you better? The 'E' is a letter, not a god."

He didn't call the guards. He didn't shout. He walked to the hearth, where a roaring fire was kept to heat the room. With a sudden, powerful heave, he hurled the Gilded E into the center of the coals.

"The gold will melt," Fredrick said, watching the emeralds crack in the heat. "And when it does, Derrick the Blacksmith will take the liquid metal. He will use it to gild the prosthetic limbs of the soldiers who lost their legs defending the North Gate. Your 'Riches' will finally do some work."

The lord fell to his knees, trembling. "Please, Sire... I meant no treason!"

"Treason is a word for those who care about crowns," Fredrick said, looking down at him. "I care about the people. Get out of my sight. And tell your friends in the E-Clan: if you want to buy my favor, bring me a shovel and stand in the mud with the Fredricks. That is the only currency I accept."

As the lord fled, Frederica stepped out from behind a curtain. She had seen the whole thing.

"You truly don't want it," she said, her voice filled with a genuine, startled awe. "The power. The wealth. You'd rather be a woodcutter."

"I am a woodcutter, Frederica," Fredrick said, his gaze returning to the fire. "I'm just working on a much larger forest now. And I think I hear the sound of a storm coming from the North."

A distant horn sounded. Not a royal horn, but the harsh, discordant blast of the House of Garrick.

"The 'Shadow' has arrived," Fredrick whispered. "Call the Council. It's time to see if the Twin Shadows can fight as well as they sign."

The horn's blast didn't just echo; it tore through the Solar of Saint Osrick like a physical blade, rattling the fine crystal carafes and extinguishing several candles. It was a sound born of the frozen wastes and the jagged peaks of the North—a sound that knew nothing of "E" or "No-E," only of conquest and the cold.

Fredrick didn't flinch. He remained standing by the hearth, the dying glow of the melted gold crown reflecting in his steady, grey eyes. Frederica, however, paled. She had spent her life navigating the whispered wars of the court, but the House of Garrick didn't whisper. They roared.

"Gather them," Fredrick commanded, his voice a low vibration that seemed to anchor the room. "Not in the throne room. Not behind closed doors. Bring the Council to the map room in the Tower of the First Twin. I want the wind at our backs when we decide how to bleed."

Edict of Unity. UBI Fredrick

The map room was a drafty, circular chamber at the highest point of the inner sanctum. A massive table of petrified oak sat in the center, carved with the topography of Alaric-Heim. For decades, the lords had used this table to argue over where the "E" territory ended and the "Legal" jurisdiction began. They had drawn lines in the dust with their daggers, carving up the kingdom into a patchwork of spite.

As the Ricks filed in, the atmosphere was thick with a new kind of tension. The petty arrogance of the previous days had been replaced by a raw, naked fear. Richard the Stern arrived with Ricarda at his side, her hand never leaving the



hilt of her sword. Alaric the Iron-Gray followed, his face set in a grim mask of war.

"The Garrick scouts have crossed the White Fork," Alaric announced without preamble, slamming a heavy iron gauntlet onto the map. "They aren't raiding. They're marching in a diamond formation. Three thousand heavy infantry, five hundred horse. They'll be at the gates of the Vale by dawn."

"And our defenses are a joke," Richard spat, though his voice lacked its usual bite. "My archers are in the East, waiting for a 'Legal' escort that hasn't arrived. Alaric's pikemen are in the West, refusing to march because they claim my quartermasters are skimming the grain."

Fredrick stepped to the table. He didn't look at the lords; he looked at the map. He saw the rivers, the bridges, and the narrow passes. He saw the kingdom not as a political entity, but as a living thing—a forest that was being surrounded by a blight.

"Enough," Fredrick said. The word was soft, yet it silenced the room instantly. "You speak of 'your' archers and 'your' pikemen. From this moment, those words are dead. There are only the defenders of Alaric-Heim. If any man mentions his clan's name before the sun sets tomorrow, I will personally throw him from these battlements."

He leaned over the map, his large, calloused hands framing the Vale of Rickard.

"Garrick expects us to hide behind our walls," Fredrick began. "He expects us to argue until his rams are at the

wood. He knows that in the past, when the North attacked, the 'E' Clan would retreat to the Citadel and let the 'Legal' peasants burn, or the 'Legal' army would stay in the fields and let the 'E' lords starve. That is the play he has practiced for eighty years."

He looked at Kenrick, the young scout who had become his shadow. "Kenrick, your scouts are the fastest. I want you to take the 'E' banners—the ones you pride so much—and ride to the North Fork. But you aren't going to fight. You're going to flee."

Kenrick's face flushed. "Flee? Sire, the Bold Rulers do not—"

"You will flee strategically," Fredrick interrupted. "Lead them into the Mire of Osrick. The heavy armor of the Garrick infantry is their greatest strength, but in the silt of the riverbank, it is their coffin. Lead them there, and make them think they are chasing a broken, disorganized rabble."

He then turned to Bardrick, the mountain of a man who represented the "Axe" of the realm. "Bardrick, you will take the 'Legal' heavy infantry. You will not stand on the walls. You will hide in the shadow of the old granaries. When Kenrick leads them into the mud, you will strike their flank. Not with a roar, but with a silent, iron wall."

"And the 'E' archers?" Frederica asked, her mind already working through the logistics.

"They will be led by Ricarda," Fredrick said, glancing at the warrior-princess. "She understands the high ground. They will take the ridges. They won't aim for the soldiers;

they will aim for the horses. A knight in the mud is a turtle on its back."

The Council watched him, mesmerized. It wasn't just the strategy; it was the way he spoke. He wasn't playing a game of chess; he was felling a tree. He knew where the weight would fall. He knew where the wood would splinter.

"This plan requires absolute trust," Alaric the Iron-Gray said, his voice hesitant. "If Kenrick doesn't turn at the right moment, my infantry will be slaughtered. If the archers don't hold the ridge, Kenrick will be cut down from behind."

"That is why it is the Law of the Twin Shadows," Fredrick replied. "A man cannot walk without his shadow. If one of you fails, all of you die. If you work together, the House of Garrick will find not a kingdom divided, but a mountain that has suddenly decided to move."

He picked up a small, iron dagger—a simple woodcutter's tool—and placed it in the center of the map.

"I am going to the North Gate," Fredrick announced. "I will not be in the rear. I will be at the point of the wedge. I want every citizen to see that their King doesn't just sign papers with two hands; he fights with one heart."

As the lords dispersed to gather their men, a strange energy took hold of the Citadel. The "E" soldiers and the "No-E" guardsmen found themselves standing side by side, checking the straps on each other's armor. The scholars were seen handing out water to the blacksmiths. The

artificial barriers that had defined their lives for generations were evaporating under the heat of a common threat.

Fredrick walked down the spiral staircase, the sound of his heavy boots a steady, reassuring rhythm. Frederica caught up to him in the courtyard.

"They are terrified, Fredrick," she whispered. "But for the first time, they are terrified of the same thing. You've done it. You've made them a people."

"I haven't done anything yet," Fredrick said, looking up at the darkening sky. "The message I sent to Garrick was a challenge. Now, we have to prove we can spell the word 'Victory' without stuttering."

The evening was spent in a flurry of activity that Alaric-Heim hadn't seen in a century. Fires were lit, but they weren't the fires of celebration; they were the fires of the forge and the cookpot. Fredrick moved among the men, speaking to them not as a distant deity, but as a fellow laborer. He helped a group of "E" archers string their longbows, his massive strength making the task look effortless. He sat with the "Legal" pikemen and showed them how to balance their weapons against a charging horse.

He was the thread weaving the two tapestries together.

As the seventh bell of the night chimed, Fredrick climbed the steps to the highest battlement of the Osrick Gate. The mist was beginning to roll in from the North, a cold, grey shroud that hid the approaching doom.

He stood there for hours, a solitary figure in a simple tunic, silhouetted against the flickering torches of the city. He felt the weight of every life below him. He thought of the forest he had left behind—the quiet peace of the larch trees and the honest sweat of the axe. He missed the simplicity of the wood, where a tree was just a tree and the wind didn't care about your name.

But as he looked out into the darkness, he heard the first faint clank of armor from the distance. He heard the muffled hoofbeats of a thousand horses. The House of Garrick was here.

He felt a presence beside him. It was Kenrick, then Bardrick, then the rest of the Council. They didn't speak. They didn't need to. They stood in a line, their shadows merging into one long, dark shape against the stone.

The time for politics was over. The time for the "E" and the "No-E" was buried in the mud. The woodcutter had prepared the ground. Now, the harvest was beginning.

The air in the Vale of Rickard had grown unnaturally still, the kind of silence that precedes a mountain slide. For eighty years, the border watchtowers of Alaric-Heim had looked inward, eyeing the "E" or "No-E" neighbors with suspicion. Now, for the first time, every eye was turned North.

On the battlements of the Osrick Gate, Fredrick stood flanked by the "Council of Ricks." The smell of damp stone and old iron was heavy. To his left, Kenrick, the "Bold Ruler," leaned over the crenellations, his knuckles white as

Edict of Unity. UBI Fredrick



he gripped his spyglass. To his right, Bardrick, the "Axe Ruler," let out a low, guttural hum, a rhythmic vibration in his chest that he always made before a slaughter.

Part IV:

The United Reich

- **Chapter 10: The Shadow of Garrick over Alaric–Heim**

—

The foreign invader arrives at the gates, testing the fragile new peace of the kingdom.

- **Chapter 11: One Blood, Two Names –**

Fredrick leads the army into the Vale of Rickard wearing the merged surcoat of the Twin Houses.

- **Chapter 12: Bridge of Unity –**

The climactic battle at the Old King's Bridge, the ancient "Warrior's Battle Chant," the final signing of the scroll, and the Concluding Song of Victory.

Chapter 10: The Shadow of Garrick over Alaric-Heim



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"They aren't just raiding, Sire," Kenrick whispered, his voice cracking the silence. "This isn't a skirmish for cattle or grain. Look at the dust clouds near Alberic's Pass."

Fredrick took the glass. Through the hazy distance, past the ruins of Didrick's Mill, he saw it. A sea of black iron. The House of Garrick had arrived, led by the infamous Garrick the Vile. They moved like a slow-moving ink blot across the green valley. There were no colorful banners here, no silver filigree—only the matte black of mercenary steel and the jagged pikes of a host that had spent decades conquering the northern wastes while Alaric-Heim argued over vowels.

"Four thousand footmen," Fredrick counted aloud, his voice flat and steady. "Six hundred heavy cavalry on the flanks. And look there, behind the vanguard... Waldrick, what do you make of those machines?"

Waldrick, the "Bright Ruler" and master scholar, stepped forward, squinting through spectacles of polished glass. "Torsion-powered catapults, Majesty. Designed to hurl fire-pots and jagged stone. They call them 'The Shatterers.' If they reach the Theodoric Bridge, they can lob stones directly into the Frederick Quarter."

"And the Fredrick District is completely exposed from the Western ridge," added Audric the Wise, his old hands trembling as they clutched a map. "They know our history. They know we are a house divided. They expect us to flee into our separate corners and let them pick us off one by one."

A sudden, sharp blast of a horn shattered the air—not the melodic call of the city, but a harsh, braying sound that felt like a physical blow to the stomach. It was the Garrick war-horn, and it was followed by the rhythmic pounding of drums made from stretched ox-hide. Boom. Boom. Boom. The sound echoed off the stone walls, a heartbeat of impending doom.

"They think we are weak," Alaric the Iron-Gray growled, his hand falling to the hilt of his heavy broadsword. "They think the 'Woodcutter King' is a man of straw."

"Let them think it," Fredrick said. He turned to the Council. The pressure in the air was immense, a physical weight on

their chests. "The House of Garrick has come for a funeral. It is up to us to decide whose it shall be."

Just then, the first Garrick catapult fired. The sound was a terrifying twang-thump, followed by a whistling hiss that set the teeth on edge. A massive stone, wrapped in burning pitch, soared through the air and smashed into the Ulrick Watchtower. The explosion of masonry and fire rained down on the streets below. Screams began to rise from the city. The suspense was over. The war had begun.



"To your posts!" Fredrick commanded. "Each of you carries the name of a ruler. Today, you earn it. Roderica, take the heralds—spread the word that the King is on the

walls. No one flees. No one hides. We stand as the Twin Shadows!"

Fredrick watched them scramble—the "Ricks" and the "E-Ricks" running side by side, their differences forgotten in the shadow of the black iron host. He felt his own heart pounding against his ribs, a frantic, rhythmic pulse that matched the Garrick drums. He looked at his calloused hands. They were the hands of a woodcutter, meant for building and for peace.

But as the second fire-pot smashed into the city, Fredrick reached for the heavy, dark breastplate Derrick had forged for him. He strapped it on, the cold steel a reminder of the "United Reich" he was trying to build.



"Let them come," Fredrick whispered into the smoke-filled wind. "The forest is thick, and the woodcutter is ready."

Suddenly, a rider burst into the courtyard below, his horse lathered in white foam. "Sire! The Hendrick Docks! A secondary force of Garrick river-raiders has seized the grain barges at the Seas of Edric! They've cut off the supply line to the Fredrick District!"

The Council erupted into chaos.

"We must send the 'Legal' guard to the docks!" Alaric shouted.

"No! We must protect the Great Library in the East!" Richard countered, his face flushing red. "The 'E' Clan's history is at stake!"

"Silence!" Fredrick's roar was like the felling of an ancient oak. The lords froze. "There is no 'Legal' guard. There is no 'E' history. There is only Alaric-Heim. Bardrick, take two hundred men—half Fredrick, half Frederick—and retake those docks. Use the Aethelric Pitch to burn their barges if you must, but do not let them land."

"And the main host?" Ricarda, the "Strong Power," asked, her eyes burning with a dark, battle-ready light. "They are five miles from the gate. We cannot hold them with words, Fredrick."

"We won't," Fredrick said. He looked at Emeric, the "Work Ruler," and Emery, the "Industrious Ruler." "Is the trap at Didrick's Mill ready?"

"The supports are weakened as you ordered, Sire," Emeric said, wiping soot from his brow. "One pull of the master lever and the entire bridge at the mill will collapse, but it requires someone to stay behind to trigger it."

"A suicide mission," Theodoric (Derek) muttered, his hand tightening on his spear.

"It is a mission for a King," Fredrick said, his eyes locking with each of them. "But I have a different plan for the bridge. We won't break it. We will use it to funnel them."

Soon the first wave of the Garrick's army was over. Some were eliminated while the others retreated as directed by their commander. They have come to test the level of the Rick's preparedness for a full assault. Thus, the people of Alaric-Heim had time for tactical retrogression and regrouping to combat the impending onslaught.

Chapter 11: One Blood, Two Names



The morning of the Great Sortie did not taste of glory; it tasted of soot, cold iron, and the metallic tang of fear. Inside the North Gate, the combined forces of Alaric-Heim stood in a formation that had never existed in eighty years of history.

On the left stood the "E-Clan" knights, their horses draped in indigo silks, their lances tipped with polished Frederick silver. On the right stood the "Legal" infantry, a wall of unadorned steel and heavy oaken shields. Between them was a gap of three paces—a lingering ghost of the old Wall—until Fredrick stepped into the center.



He was no longer the woodcutter in a hemp tunic. He wore the dark, hammered breastplate from Derrick's forge, but over it, he wore a custom-sewn surcoat. On the left side, it bore the intricate embroidery of the House of Frederick; on the right, the bold, block-lettered crest of the House of Fredrick. In the center, the two designs were stitched together with gold thread into a single, seamless Shield of the Twins.

"Look at him," whispered Theodoric, his voice trembling as he adjusted his helmet. "He wears both names. He wears us both."

Fredrick mounted his horse, a sturdy bay that didn't flinch at the smell of smoke. He turned to the Council. Alaric the Iron-Gray and Richard the Gilded sat on their chargers, their eyes fixed on the King.

"Today, we do not march to defend a wall," Fredrick's voice carried through the courtyard, amplified by the silent, stone walls. "We march to defend the ground beneath it. The House of Garrick thinks we are two houses. They think if they strike the 'E,' the 'Legal' will stand aside. They think if they crush the 'Legal,' the 'E' will surrender for gold."

He drew his sword—not the gilded blade of the treasury, but the heavy, functional steel of a protector.

"Show them they are wrong. Show them that when you bleed, the blood is the same color. Show them that one name is no stronger than the other, but together, we are the stone they cannot break! Open the gates!"

The Osrick Gate groaned as Bardrick and Emeric threw their combined weight into the iron winches. As the massive timber doors swung wide, the sight of the Vale of Rickard met them.

The Garrick host was a black tide, already moving. Their heavy cavalry—the "Black-Ricks" of the North—were trotting forward, their lances leveled. Behind them, the "Shatterers" loosed another volley of fire-pots that hissed over the heads of the King's army.

"Form the Unified Line!" Fredrick roared.

The maneuver was the most dangerous part of the "Peace Ruler's Gambit." The "E" knights, under Ricarda's command, galloped forward, but instead of charging, they split to the wings. The "Legal" infantry, led by Alaric, marched to the center

"They're leaving the center open!" shouted Garrick the Vile from his distant command hill. "The fools! Charge the gap! Break the woodcutter's heart!"

The Garrick cavalry hammered forward, a thousand tons of horse and iron. The ground shook. The suspense in the Alaric-Heim line was a physical cord, stretched to the snapping point.

"Hold!" Fredrick commanded, his horse prancing at the head of the infantry.

"Sire, they are nearly upon us!" Kenrick shouted, his hand twitching on his bowstring.

"Hold!"

The Garrick cavalry was fifty paces away. Forty. Thirty.

"Now! Emeric! The Trap!"

At the edge of the Didrick's Mill path, a team of laborers pulled a master lever. A series of hidden iron spikes, forged by Derrick and hidden beneath a thin layer of turf and straw, sprang upward.

The lead Garrick horses screamed as they were impaled. The charge collapsed into a chaotic pile of thrashing limbs and shattered lances.

"Archers, loose!" Fredrick bellowed.

From the wings, the "E" archers, coordinated by Ulrica and Roderica, loosed a coordinated volley. Because they were positioned on the high embankments, their arrows rained down on the exposed flanks of the Garrick infantry, who were struggling to push past their fallen cavalry.

"Infantry, advance!" Fredrick lowered his sword and spurred his horse.

The "Legal" Fredricks and the "E" Fredericks crashed into the Garrick line as one. It was a brutal, heart-pounding symphony of steel on steel. Bardrick swung his great-axe, clearing a path for Theodoric's spear-men. Alaric and Richard fought back-to-back, the "Brave Ruler" and the "Gilded Ruler" protecting each other's blind spots.

Fredrick was a whirlwind in the center. He didn't seek out the enemy captains; he moved to wherever the line was

weakest. When a "Legal" soldier fell, Fredrick was there to pull him back while an "E" healer, sent by Cedrica, rushed forward.

"Look!" a Garrick soldier screamed in terror, pointing at Fredrick. "He is two kings in one!"

The psychological blow was as heavy as the physical one. The House of Garrick had expected a civil war; they found a singular, unbreakable wall of "Rick" power.

By midday, the Garrick vanguard was broken. They began to retreat toward the Old King's Bridge, but Fredrick didn't let up. He knew that to stop now was to invite a counter-siege.

"To the bridge!" Fredrick shouted, his face splattered with the soot of battle and the sweat of exertion. "One blood! One names! Alaric-Heim!"

As they pushed the enemy back, the soldiers began to chant. It wasn't "Fredrick" or "Frederick." It was a rhythmic, guttural roar: "RICK! RICK! RICK!" The names had finally merged into a single sound of power.

Chapter 12: Bridge of Unity



The sun hung like a dying ember over the Vale of Rickard, casting a blood-red sheen across the churned mud and broken iron of the battlefield. The air was thick—not just with the smoke of the "Shatterers," but with a tension so heavy it felt as though the sky itself might crack. For eighty years, this valley had been a place of ghosts. Today, it was the birthplace of a legend.

The House of Garrick had reformed on the northern slope. Garrick the Vile stood atop his black-armored charger, his voice carrying like a scavenger's cry. "Look at them!" he mocked, pointing toward the bridge. "A woodcutter leading a flock of sheep! The 'E' will run when the 'Legal' falls, and the 'Legal' will break when the 'E' cowers! Advance! Crush the divided!"



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But Fredrick did not move. He stood at the center of the Old King's Bridge, his dark breastplate reflecting the crimson sun. He looked to his left at Lord Richard, then to his right at Baron Alaric. He saw the exhaustion in their eyes, but he also saw something new: a reflection. For the first time, they weren't looking at each other's banners; they were looking at each other's scars.

"They think we are two," Fredrick said, his voice a low rumble that seemed to rise from the earth itself. "Let us show them the math of the Twins."

He slammed his shield with the flat of his blade. CLANG.

The sound was echoed by Bardrick the Axe Ruler. CLANG. Then by Kenrick the Bold. CLANG. Slowly, the rhythmic drumming began to spread through the ranks. It wasn't a noise; it was a heartbeat. And then, the ancient mantra—the one that had been whispered in nurseries and suppressed in courts for eighty years—burst forth from four thousand throats.

The Charging Mantra of the Ricks

(The earth began to tremble as the boots hit the ground in perfect unison – Left... Right... Left...)

IRON!!!!!!

IRON in the marrow!

IRON in the bone!

TWO hearts beating for a single throne!

Edict of Unity. UBI Fredrick

The Garrick mercenaries hesitated. They had heard the songs of the Fredericks and the war-cries of the Fredricks, but they had never heard this. It was a sound of tectonic plates shifting.

One for the STRENGTH!

One for the VOICE!

The blood is the BLOOD!

There is no CHOICE!

The speed of the drumbeat increased. The "E" archers on the ridges and the "Legal" infantry on the bridge began to move as a single, undulating wave of steel.

BY THE STEADFAST!

BY THE ELOQUENT!

WE ARE THE SHIELD!

WE ARE THE ELEMENT!

THE 'E' IS THE FIRE!

THE 'RICK' IS THE COAL!

TWO HALVES BREAKING TO MAKE US WHOLE!"

As they reached the base of the slope, the chant reached a deafening fever pitch.

HEAR the thunder!

FEEL the strike!

NOT A FREDERICK!

NOT A FREDRICK!

WE! ARE! RICK!

WE! ARE! RICK!!

WE! ARE! RICK!!!

With a roar that shattered the remaining glass in the distant watchtowers, the army of Alaric-Heim charged. The collision was cataclysmic. Bardrick and Theodoric fought



as a singular machine—the axe clearing the way for the spear. Fredrick was at the very tip, a whirlwind of measured, rhythmic strikes.

By the time the moon rose, the House of Garrick was broken. They fled into the northern wastes, leaving behind a kingdom that had finally found its pulse.

The silence that followed the battle was heavier than the noise of the conflict. Thousands of men and women stood on the banks of the River Edric, their breath hitching in the cold night air. The "E" and the "No-E" stood side-by-side, looking at the same moon, bleeding the same red blood into the same soil with torches. They set up a table for a great family reunion ceremony.

The roar of the final charge did not end with cheers; it faded into a long, ragged exhale that seemed to drain the very air from the valley. As the last of the Garrick banners disappeared into the northern mist, the adrenaline that had fueled the "Twin Shadows" evaporated, leaving behind a bone-deep weariness that made shields feel like lead and spears like anchors.

The transition from warriors to survivors happened in the quiet gaps between the groans of the wounded. There was no immediate celebration. Instead, there was the heavy, rhythmic sound of boots dragging through the blood-slicked mud as the men turned back toward the River Edric.

For three days, the valley became a city of tents and flickering watch-fires. The "E-Clan" knights dismounted not to feast, but to help the "Legal" infantry carry the dead to the high ridges. In the makeshift infirmaries, Ricarda and Ulrica worked until their hands were stained dark, passing bandages to healers who no longer asked which ledger a soldier's name was written in. Men who had spent decades

Edict of Unity. UBI Fredrick

bickering over the "Maritime Tax" now sat around the same fires, sharing charred bread and passing skins of sour wine in a silence that was more profound than any decree.

They washed the soot from their faces in the river, the grey water carrying away the grime of eighty years of spite. They watched the blacksmiths—Derrick at the lead—work through the nights, not to forge new swords, but to hammer out the dents in the armor of their neighbors.

They decided to build a wall round around their entire kingdom. Audric, the Wise Ruler, thus commissioned Emeric, the Work Ruler and Waldrick, the Bright Ruler, to supervise the drawing by Patrick, a Nobleman, skilled in building and his ‘son of the reddish-brown’, Broderick.



By the fourth evening, the camp had grown still. The dead were buried, the wounded were stabilized, and the stench

of the pyres had been carried away by a fresh wind from the South. The soldiers gathered on the banks of the Edric, a sea of indigo and unadorned steel that had bled into a single, bruised purple under the twilight.

It was only then, when the exhaustion had turned into a solemn clarity, that Fredrick emerged from his command tent. He still wore the dark breastplate, now scarred by Garrick steel, but he moved with the slow, deliberate pace of a man who had finished his day's labor in the wood. He didn't call for a parade. He simply walked to the center of the Old King's Bridge.

"Bring the table," Fredrick commanded.

Emeric the Work Ruler and Emery the Industrious Ruler stepped forward. They carried a simple wooden trestle, scarred by years of use, and placed it exactly over the central seam of the bridge—the literal dividing line between the East and West. Audric the Wise stepped forward, unrolling a massive, blank scroll of vellum. Beside it, he placed the hawk-feather quill.

Fredrick looked at the Council. The lords were battered; Richard's silk was shredded, and Alaric's plate was dented.

"Eighty years ago," Fredrick began, his voice echoing over the water, "two brothers died on a ridge to save a kingdom. We spent the next eight decades trying to tear it apart over a letter. We forgot the most basic moral of leadership: A house divided against itself cannot stand, but a house that builds its walls out of spite will eventually be buried by them."

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He turned to the desk. He signaled for Lord Richard of the E-Clan to step forward. Richard, hesitant, took the quill.

"Write the name," Fredrick commanded.

Richard, the man who had spent his life insisting on the 'E', dipped the quill in the ink. With a trembling hand, he wrote the name in the ancient, legal style: FREDRICK. He left no space for the 'E'. He looked at the word—the name of the "Legal" lineage—and he bowed his head.



Then, Fredrick signaled for Baron Alaric of the "No-E" clan. The gruff warrior stepped to the desk. He took the same quill from Richard's hand. Their fingers brushed, and for the first time, neither pulled away. Alaric looked at the name Richard had written. With a steady, deliberate hand,

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he reached into the center of the word and added the middle E, transforming it into FREDERICK.

The crowd gasped. The act was a linguistic surrender and a spiritual triumph. They had used each other's signatures to complete the identity of the realm.

"This is the Law of the Twin Shadows," Fredrick announced. "Unity is not the absence of difference, but the alignment of purpose. From this day forward, the 'E' is the Bridge, and the 'Rick' is the Pillar. One cannot stand without the other."

The signing continued with a heavy, rhythmic solemnity. One by one, the "Ricks" stepped forward to add their mark to the Edict of Unity:

Alarice and Alaric (Rulers of All)

Ricarda and Richard (Strong/Brave Rulers)

Ulrica and Ulrick (Noble Power/Rulers)

Cedrica and Cedric (Gifted/Bounty Rulers)

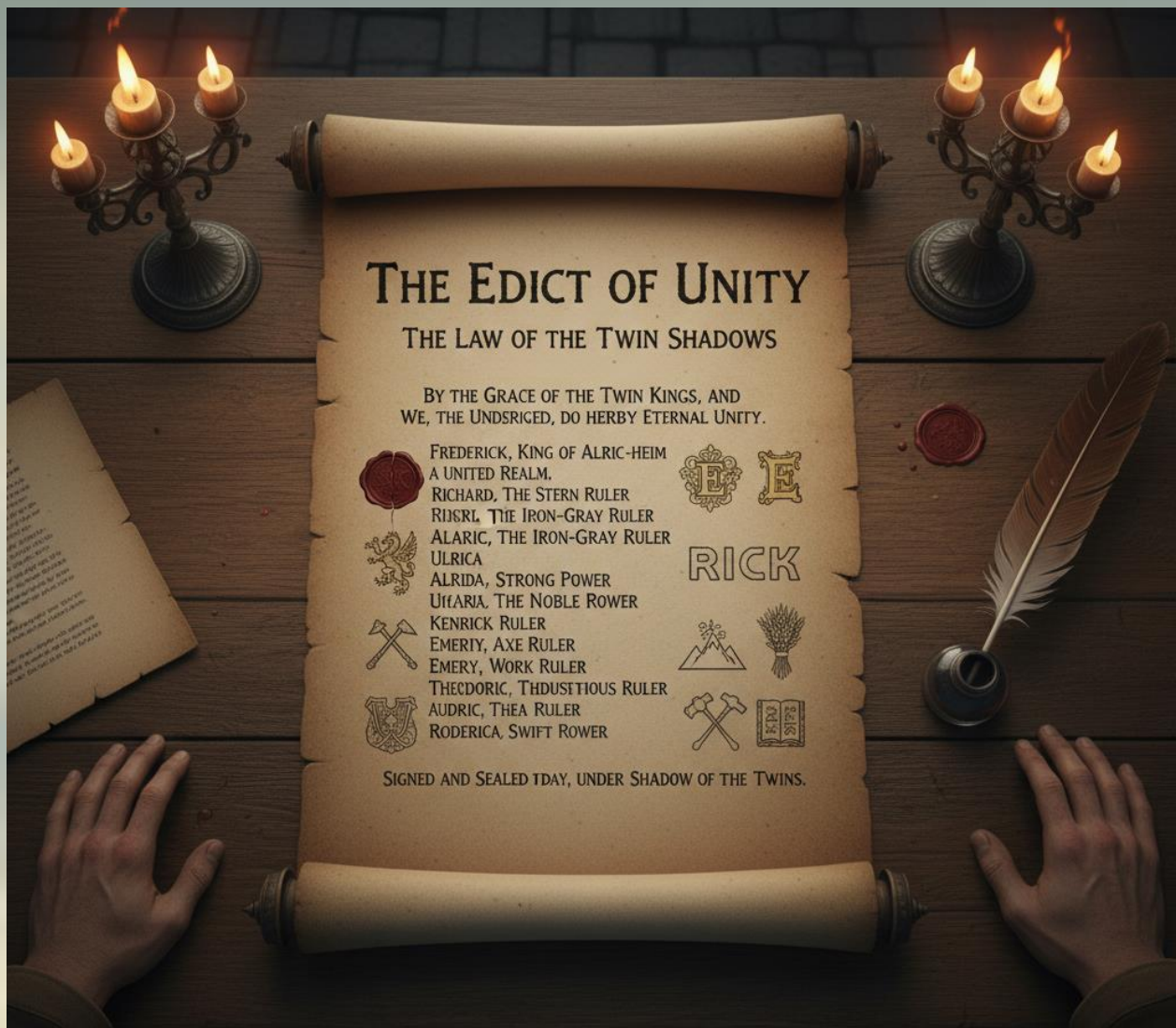
Emery and Emeric (Industrious/Work Rulers)

Roderica and Roderick (Famous Power/Rulers)

Kenrick (Bold Ruler), Bardrick (Axe Ruler), and Theodoric (People's Ruler).

When the last name was inscribed, Fredrick took the iron circlet from Audric. He did not place it on his head immediately. He held it out for the people to see.

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"You ask me to rule," Fredrick said, his voice dropping to a somber, intimate tone. "I will accept this burden, but hear me well. Power is not a prize to be won; it is a loan from the people. I will sit on the throne for a season—long enough to ensure the walls are down, the granaries are shared, and the laws are signed by both hands. But when the first leaf of autumn falls, I shall return to my woods. For the final moral of this journey is this: A true leader knows when to pick up the axe, but more importantly, he knows when to put it down."

He placed the crown on his head. The cheers did not erupt immediately; instead, a low, melodic hum began. It was the

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Song of Unity, starting slow and somber, like a funeral for the old hate, before rising into a thunderous victory.

The Song of the United Reich

(Verse 1 – Slow, haunting, solo voice)

The sun has set on the Vale of Tears; the fire has ceased to glow.

The ghosts of eighty bitter years are laid in the mud below.

We fought for a letter, we fought for a line, we fought for a hollow pride.

While the soul of the kingdom withered away and the hope of the people died.

(Chorus – Gathering strength, rhythmic stomps begin)

Oh, Alaric-Heim is rising! One blood and two names!

The Peace Ruler has conquered all our vanity and shames!

The ‘E’ is the Bridge, and the ‘Rick’ is the Stone,

We march as a thousand, but we stand as one alone!

(Verse 2 – Faster, with the clashing of shields)

From the Hendrick Docks to the Osrick Gate, the story is written in gold,

How the Woodcutter stayed the tyrant’s hand and brought us into the fold.

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*He showed us in the silence, he showed us in the mud,
That you cannot wash away the truth of ancient, royal
blood!*

(Chorus – High energy, joyful and loud)

Oh, Alaric-Heim is rising! One blood and two names!

*The Peace Ruler has conquered all our vanity and
shames!*

The ‘E’ is the Bridge, and the ‘Rick’ is the Stone,

We march as a thousand, but we stand as one alone!

(Bridge – A soaring, melodic chant)

No more the wall! (WE ARE RICK!)

No more the divide! (WE ARE RICK!)

The Steadfast and the Eloquent are walking side-by-side!

*Stitch the surcoat, seal the scroll, make the broken
kingdom whole!*

(Final Chorus – Maximum volume, triumphant roar)

Oh, Alaric-Heim is rising! One blood and two names!

*The Peace Ruler has conquered all our vanity and
shames!*

The ‘E’ is the Bridge, and the ‘Rick’ is the Stone,

We march as a thousand, but we stand as one alone!

LONG! LIVE! THE RICK!

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As the final note echoed off the mountains, Fredrick stood at the rail of the bridge. He felt the weight of the crown, but for the first time, it didn't feel like a cage. It felt like a promise.

Then the new map of the kingdom was brought to Fredrick. He looked at it and it was perfect. He called the respective rulers according to their Houses and they all saw it and approve of it. Immediately, preparations were made to begin the work. It will be the new Kingdom of Alaric-Heim.



Edict of Unity. UBI Fredrick

He looked at Richard and Alaric, who were now discussing the reconstruction of the North Gate together. He saw Ricarda and Ulrica organizing the transport of the wounded, regardless of their clan.

"The wood is cleared," Fredrick whispered to the night wind. "Now, let the forest grow."

He knew his time on the throne would be short, but he knew the foundation was solid. He had taught them that Greed is a vowel that chokes the heart, and that Mercy is the only ink that never fades.

The "Edict of Unity" was not just a piece of parchment; it was the heartbeat of a people who had finally learned that their strength lay not in being identical, but in being inseparable.

The Royal Register of Alaric-Heim



SN	Name/ Meaning	Clan	Persona
1.	Fredrick (The Steadfast) -Peace Ruler The Ancient Past (The Original Twin).	The "Legal" spelling (No-E)	The Shield: He was the warrior and the protector. He represents the "Iron" and the "Marrow" of the lineage. The Survivor (Briefly): He held the ridge until the very end, dying with his brother's hand in his. The Legacy: His name became the banner for the "Fredricks"—the traditionalists who valued iron, hard work, and ancient law. They viewed the "E" as an unnecessary luxury that weakened the name.
2.	Frederick (The Eloquent) -Peace Ruler The Ancient Past (The Original Twin).	Spelled with the middle "E". (E-Clan)	The Visionary: He was the diplomat and the scholar. In the legends, he represents the "Voice" of the twins. The Martyr: He died on the Ridge of the Twin Shadows alongside his brother, taking two arrows to the chest to protect him. The Legacy: After his death, his name was weaponized by the "E-Clan" (the Fredericks) to represent superiority, education, and "high" royalty. His sacrifice was forgotten, replaced by a fight over his spelling.
3.	Fredrick (The Woodcutter) -Peace Ruler The Present Day (The Protagonist).	No-E	The Reluctant King: A humble woodcutter from Stone-Brook who preferred the shade of larch trees to the gold of the palace. The Master Strategist: Unlike his ancestors who fought with swords, he fought with silence and morals. He was "diversified," much like his creator, using logic to outplay the greedy lords.

Edict of Unity. UBI Fredrick

			The Bridge-Builder: He is the one who finally wore the dual-crested surcoat, proving that he could be both "Steadfast" and "Eloquent." The Leader of Release: His defining trait was his willingness to give up power once the "Edict of the Bridge" was signed, returning to his forest once the kingdom was whole.
4.	Alaric -Ruler of All	No-E	The fierce Baron of the West. A master of defense who eventually added the "E" to the King's name to prove his loyalty.
5.	Alarice -Ruler of All	No-E	A vault-master of the West. She proved that "Ruling All" meant protecting the common food supply during the siege.
6.	Audric -Wise Ruler	E-Clan	The kingdom's conscience. He mentored the Woodcutter King in the "Wise" traditions of the ancient court.
7.	Bardrick -Axe Ruler	No-E	The Captain of the Guard. He turned the rhythm of the woodcutter's axe into a rhythmic war-drum on the bridge.
8.	Cedric -Bounty Ruler	No-E	The Master of Granaries. He learned that a "Bounty" shared is a kingdom saved.
9.	Cedrica -Gifted Ruler	E-Clan	A master healer who learned that her "Gift" was meant for all bloodlines, not just those with an "E."
10.	Edric -Wealthy Ruler	E-Clan	The Master of Coin who realized that "Wealth" is found in a brother's life, not a chest of gold.
11.	Emeric -Work Ruler	No-E	The hammer-wielding mason of the West who taught Emery that "Work" is the foundation of industry.
12.	Emery -Industrious Ruler	E-Clan	A sophisticated architect of the East who eventually labored in the mud to build the new North Gate.

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13.	Frederica -Peaceful Ruler	E-Clan	The counterpart to the Woodcutter, she served as the bridge to the female "Alpha" leaders of the E-Clan.
14.	Hendrick Ruler of Home	No-E	The Castellan who turned the palace from a fortress of secrets into a "Home" for all Ricks.
15.	Kenrick -Bold Ruler	No-E	A hot-headed scout whose "Boldness" allowed him to spot the enemy "Shatterers" before they could fire.
16.	Ricarda -Strong Power	E-Clan	Richard's daughter. A sharp, "Alpha" strategist who recognized Fredrick's true authority before the men did.
17.	Richard -Brave Ruler	E-Clan	A wealthy lord obsessed with "Riches." He was the first to surrender his pride by signing the Edict without the "E."
18.	Roderica -Famous Power	E-Clan	A social influencer who used her "Fame" to spread the King's message of hope to the hearing-impaired.
19.	Roderick -Famous Ruler	No-E	The High Herald. His thunderous voice led the "Charging Mantra" that terrified the House of Garrick.
20.	Theodoric -People's Ruler	No-E	Also known as "Derrick" the Blacksmith. Fredrick's closest friend and the voice of the common man.
21.	Ulrica -Noble Power	E-Clan	The High Priestess of archives. She used "Noble" knowledge to find the tactical oils needed to burn the enemy's war machines.
22.	Ulrick -Noble Ruler	No-E	An elder warrior who believed nobility was born of scars and iron, not books and vowels.
23.	Waldrick -Bright Ruler	E-Clan	A military strategist whose "Bright" intellect mapped the river-flooding trap that drowned the invaders.

Glossary of Places



The Glossary of Places serves as the cartography of a kingdom once broken by a vowel and rebuilt by the axe. From the granite-scarred streets of the capital to the mist-shrouded forests of the north, every location in Alaric-Heim tells a story of the divide and the eventual unity.

THE HEART OF THE REALM

1. **Alaric-Heim:**

The High Kingdom of the Midlands. Traditionally a land of fertile vales and iron-rich mountains, it became a fractured state defined by the "Great Divide" before its reunification under the Woodcutter King.

2. **Oakhaven:**

The capital city of the realm. It is divided into two distinct halves: the Frederick Quarter (East), known for its gilded spires and libraries, and the Fredrick District (West), known for its ironworks and military barracks.

3. **The Wall of the Suffix:**

The jagged, granite divide that ran through the heart of Oakhaven for eighty years. It was dismantled by the people to reinforce the city's gates during the Garrick invasion.

4. **The Old King's Bridge:**

The ancient stone span crossing the River Edric. It is the site of the original twins' last stand and the location where the Edict of Unity was finally signed.

THE SACRED & THE SCHOLARLY

5. **The Chamber of the Gilded 'E':**

The royal meeting hall in the Eastern palace. Once a place of exclusive E-Clan plotting, it became the neutral ground for the Council of Ricks.

6. **The Monastery of Saint Osrick:**

A secluded stone abbey where the true genealogies of the Twin Houses were hidden during the riots of the "Fortieth Year."

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7. **The Hendrick Tower:**

The central watch-post of the city, named for the "Ruler of the Home." It overlooks the neutral zone and served as Fredrick's modest living quarters.

8. **The Hall of Records:**

The repository of the realm's laws and ledgers, where the spelling of a name could determine a man's taxes or his freedom.

THE WILDERNESS & THE FRONTIER

9. **The Shadow-Woods:**

A massive, ancient forest thirty miles north of the capital. It is home to the hamlet of Stone-Brook, where Fredrick lived as a woodcutter in total anonymity.

10. **The Vale of Rickard:**

The vast, fertile valley surrounding the capital. It was the primary battleground against the House of Garrick and the site of the "River-Flooding Trap."

11. **The Seas of Edric:**

A network of massive inland lakes and rivers that provide the kingdom's primary trade routes. Its waters are cold, deep, and essential for the Hendrick Docks.

12. **Alberic's Pass:**

The narrow mountain opening in the North through which the House of Garrick launched their invasion. It is named for the "Elf Ruler" of legend.

THE GATES & DEFENSES

13. **The Theodoric Gate:**

The "People's Gate." The main southern entrance to Oakhaven, where the common folk traditionally gathered to hear royal decrees.

14. **The Osrick Gate (North Gate):**

The most heavily fortified gate of the city. It was nearly breached by the Garrick ram before being reinforced with the stones of the fallen Wall.

15. **Edric's Ridge:**

The high ground overlooking the Vale of Rickard. It served as the strategic vantage point for the "E" archers during the final battle.

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16. The Didrick Mill:

A strategic watermill on the River Edric used by Fredrick to funnel the Garrick cavalry into the marshlands



Moral Lexicon



In the chronicles of Alaric-Heim, the reign of the Woodcutter King was defined not by the territory he conquered, but by the truths he restored. These four pillars, known as the Moral Lexicon, were inscribed upon the base of the "Silent Throne" to ensure that no future ruler would ever again mistake a letter for a life.

I. The Pillar of Purpose

"Unity is not the absence of difference, but the alignment of purpose."

The Great Divide persisted because the clans believed that to be "United," one side had to vanish. The Fredericks sought to erase the "crude" Fredricks, and the Fredricks sought to tear down the "haughty" Fredericks. Fredrick the Woodcutter taught them that a bridge requires two distinct banks to stand. Their differences—the iron of the West and the silk of the East—were not weaknesses to be purged, but unique tools that, when aligned, could withstand even the fires of the House of Garrick.

II. The Pillar of Stewardship

"Power is a loan from the people, not a gift from the heavens."

For eighty years, the Council of Ricks acted as though the kingdom was a trophy to be possessed. They fought over the "Riches" of the name while the people starved. This moral

Edict of Unity. UBI Fredrick

reminds the ruler that the crown is a heavy burden of service, not a decoration of vanity. To lead is to be the servant of the "Rick" who plows the field; if the people are not fed, the throne is nothing more than a gilded chair in an empty room.

III. The Pillar of Substance

"Greed is a vowel that chokes the heart."

This lesson was born from the melting of the Gilded 'E'. The lords were obsessed with the "appearance" of power—the spelling of names, the shine of gold, and the prestige of titles. Fredrick proved that true wealth is found in the substance of a man's character. A name, no matter how elegantly spelled, is hollow if the heart behind it is filled with envy. Only when the "Riches" were used to heal the wounded did the gold finally serve a kingly purpose.

IV. The Pillar of Release

"A leader's greatest victory is knowing when his work is done."

The most difficult lesson Fredrick taught was the morality of the exit. Tyranny is born when a ruler fears the return to the "shade." By stepping down at the height of his glory, Fredrick ensured that the law—not the man—remained supreme. He taught the kingdom that a true protector clears the forest so that others may grow, and that the ultimate proof of a leader's success is a people who no longer need him to tell them how to be whole.

The Author



UBI, Fredrick is a polymath of the modern age—an art lover, author, and songwriter who has spent years meticulously compiling snippets of poems, lines of plays, and profound motivational quotations. His work is a testament to the power of inspiration, blending a legendary storytelling style with the precision of a 21st-century tech enthusiast. With a diversified interest cutting across the arts and sciences, Mr. UBI Fredrick crafts narratives that are not merely read, but experienced.

His literary portfolio, including the renowned "Rise of the Alpha Female" and this latest masterpiece, "The United Reich," showcases his signature style: a careful choice of words that paints perfect word pictures. By integrating AI-generated imagery to create a vivid mental vision and native audio versions that allow readers to sing and dance along with his characters, he transforms the traditional storyline into a multisensory reality.

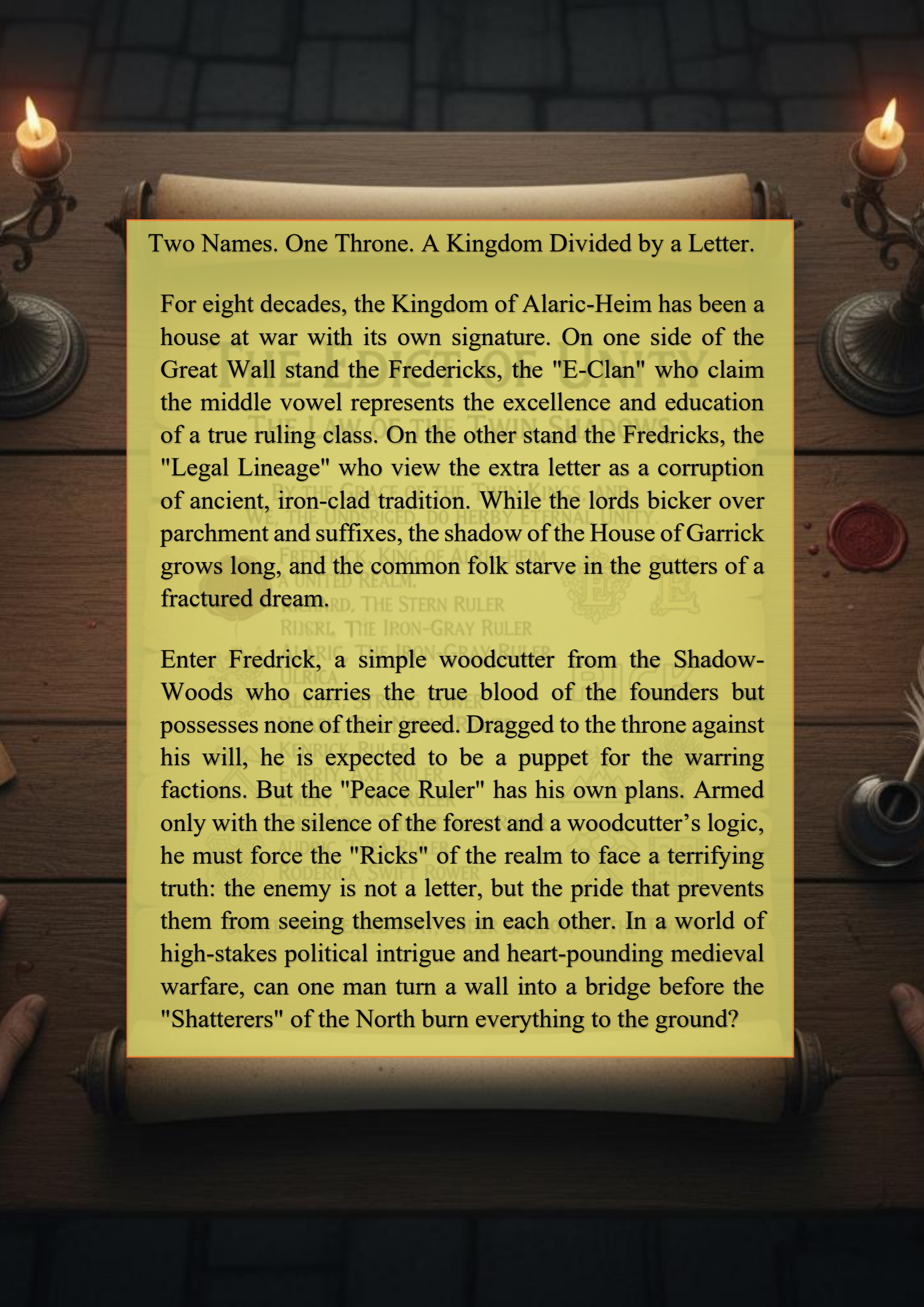
The naming conventions in his works are often born from a unique creative spark; just as "Rise of the Alpha Female" was motivated by a collection of "K" names, his latest work explores the deep linguistic tension within the "Rick" dynasty. Each book features a detailed Profiling Page, meticulously listing the descriptions, ages, physical identifications, and qualities of every character and place. While these names and settings are fictional and any resemblance to actual persons or places is purely coincidental, they are grounded in a realism that invites the reader to walk alongside them.

Beyond the written word, Mr. UBI Fredrick is a man of deep service. In addition to his understanding of Level One Braille, he is a distinguished sign language instructor and interpreter, with an effective command of American Sign Language (ASL), British Sign Language (BSL), and Nigerian Sign Language (NNS).

He lives by the philosophy that knowledge is for the living and must be shared. As a considerate and reasonable fellow, he respects all but remains unyielding on the side of the truth. This truth—a glorious hope—he shares voluntarily and tirelessly, ensuring his voice reaches everyone, including those within the hearing-impaired community.

Ubi Fredrick

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Two Names. One Throne. A Kingdom Divided by a Letter.

For eight decades, the Kingdom of Alaric-Heim has been a house at war with its own signature. On one side of the Great Wall stand the Fredericks, the "E-Clan" who claim the middle vowel represents the excellence and education of a true ruling class. On the other stand the Fredricks, the "Legal Lineage" who view the extra letter as a corruption of ancient, iron-clad tradition. While the lords bicker over parchment and suffixes, the shadow of the House of Garrick grows long, and the common folk starve in the gutters of a fractured dream.

Enter Fredrick, a simple woodcutter from the Shadow-Woods who carries the true blood of the founders but possesses none of their greed. Dragged to the throne against his will, he is expected to be a puppet for the warring factions. But the "Peace Ruler" has his own plans. Armed only with the silence of the forest and a woodcutter's logic, he must force the "Ricks" of the realm to face a terrifying truth: the enemy is not a letter, but the pride that prevents them from seeing themselves in each other. In a world of high-stakes political intrigue and heart-pounding medieval warfare, can one man turn a wall into a bridge before the "Shatterers" of the North burn everything to the ground?